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Does Proximity Matter? Terrorism Salience Following the 2015 Paris Attacks

Relatore: Chiar.mo Prof. Nicola Pontarollo

Correlatore: Chiar.mo Prof. Giovanni Maria Abbiati

Laureanda:

Chiara Pizzetti

Matricola n. 735121

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Introduction

Terrorism represents a form of political violence whose effects can extend well beyond its direct victims. Although the probability of becoming a direct victim is relatively low, terrorist attacks can generate widespread fear and increase public concern about security and terrorism (Nussio et al., 2021). More broadly, terrorist violence has been shown to affect public opinion and a range of political attitudes, including trust in institutions, political behavior and attitudes towards immigration (Dinesen & Jæger, 2013; Legewie, 2013; Balcells & Torrats-Espinosa, 2018; Nussio et al., 2019; Nägel et al., 2024). An important consequence of terrorist attacks is therefore their ability to shape the political importance citizens attach to terrorism as an issue (Nussio et al., 2021; de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone, 2021). In this thesis, this dimension is captured through terrorism salience, defined as the extent to which citizens identify terrorism as one of the most important problems facing their country.

Previous research shows that terrorist attacks can substantially increase terrorism salience. Nussio et al. (2021) find that the November 2015 Paris attacks increase attention to terrorism both in France and, to a lesser extent, across Europe. However, whether this response varies with geographical proximity remains unclear. While Nussio et al. (2019) find no evidence that proximity systematically intensified the effects of the Paris attacks on migration attitudes, Böhmelt et al. (2020) provide evidence that geographical proximity can condition the diffusion of terrorism-related effects for other outcomes. These contrasting findings across different outcomes raise the question of whether proximity to terrorism should be understood only in geographical terms. Previous exposure to terrorism may represent an additional form of contextual or experiential proximity, as populations that have already experienced terrorist violence may process subsequent attacks through pre-existing interpretative frameworks (Criado, 2017). This thesis therefore considers both geographical proximity and previous exposure to terrorism when examining the cross-national response to a terrorist attack.

The analysis focuses on the Paris attacks of 13 November 2015. France represents a particularly informative case because the attacks occurred in a country with a long history of terrorism and recent exposure to jihadist violence (Brouard et al., 2018). The November attacks therefore took place against a background in which terrorism was already an established political and security concern, while representing an exceptionally severe event. This combination makes the French case particularly relevant for examining changes in terrorism issue salience following a major terrorist attack.

The timing of the attacks also provides a particularly suitable setting for the empirical analysis. The Eurobarometer 84.3 survey was conducted between 7 and 17 November 2015, meaning that interviews were carried out both immediately before and after the attacks. This unexpected occurrence during an ongoing survey allows the event to be studied through an Unexpected Event during Survey Design (UESD) approach, as systemized by Muñoz et al. (2020), comparing respondents interviewed before and after the attack.

The central research question of this thesis is therefore: does proximity to a terrorist attack, whether geographical or experiential, condition its effect on terrorism issue salience?

To answer this question, the analysis examines three related dimensions. First, it assesses the response in France, where the attacks occurred and where terrorism already represented an established concern. Second, it examines whether the response follows a spatial gradient, by comparing France with neighboring countries and the rest of Europe. Third, it considers whether previous exposure to terrorism provides an alternative dimension of proximity that may help explain differences in the response across countries. The main analysis uses a three-day window around the attack, comparing respondents interviewed before and after 13 November, while excluding interviews conducted on the day of the event.

This thesis contributes to the literature in three main ways. First, it provides further evidence on the public-opinion consequences of the Paris attacks while highlighting the importance of considering the specific context in which a terrorist attack occurs. Second, it provides a more detailed examination of geographical proximity than comparing France with the rest of Europe by explicitly considering neighboring countries as an intermediate group. Third, it extends the concept of proximity beyond physical distance by examining whether previous exposure to terrorism may represent a relevant form of contextual or experiential proximity.

The remainder of the thesis is organized as follows. Chapter 1 presents the theoretical framework and reviews the relevant literature. Chapter 2 describes the data and empirical strategy used in the analysis. Chapter 3 discusses the assumptions underlying the UESD design. Chapter 4 presents the main results and robustness analyses. Finally, Chapter 5 concludes by discussing the main findings. The limitations of the analysis and directions for future research are reported in the Conclusion Section.

1. Theoretical Framework

1.1 Terrorism and Issue Salience

Terrorism can be understood as a form of political violence whose effects extend beyond its direct victims, generating broader psychological and political consequences for the population. Although the probability of becoming a direct victim of terrorism is low, terrorism can nevertheless generate levels of public fear and political concern that far exceed the objective risk of victimization. Over the recent decades, terrorism has become an important policy priority and a central concern for citizens across Western democracies, with potentially far-reaching consequences for democratic institutions, electoral behavior and individual well-being (Nussio et al., 2021). More broadly, terrorist attacks have been shown to affect public opinion and a range of political attitudes and preferences. Previous research has examined how terrorist attacks influence public trust in government institutions (Dinesen & Jæger, 2013; Nägel et al., 2024), political behavior (Balcells & Torrats-Espinosa, 2018) and attitudes toward immigration (Legewie, 2013; Nussio et al., 2019). These changes may in turn shape political behavior and policymaking more broadly, influencing security regulation, processes of radicalization, and even decisions concerning the use of military force (Nussio et al., 2021).

The disproportionate influence of this phenomenon is closely connected to its communicative nature. As de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone (2021) argue, terrorism is not primarily about killing, but about reaching an audience beyond the direct victims, with the attack itself serving as a means of sending a message to a wider public. Terrorist violence can therefore produce consequences that extend well beyond the individuals and locations directly affected. In this sense, attracting the attention of a broader audience represents a central component of the logic through which terrorism can generate political and social effects (de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone, 2021; Nussio et al., 2021).

Precisely because this audience's attention is finite, political issues compete for limited space on the public agenda. An increase in the prominence of one issue may consequently correspond to a decline in attention to others (Zhu, 1992). In this context Brosius and Kepplinger (1995) describe certain issues as *killer issues*, namely issues capable of rapidly displacing competing concerns from public attention. This dynamic has since been refined by Geiß (2018), who argues that media attention to issues does not simply rise and fall along a single dimension, but follows more differentiated patterns that vary in intensity, duration, and thematic scope. Building on this logic, Nussio et al. (2021) characterize terrorism as a potential killer issue, given its capacity to suddenly capture public attention

and alter the relative importance attributed to different societal problems. Terrorist attacks may therefore affect public opinion not only by changing specific political attitudes but, more fundamentally, by changing which issues citizens consider important.

This capacity of terrorism to capture and potentially dominate public attention is best examined through the concept of *issue salience*, which constitutes the central outcome of interest in this thesis. As de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone (2021) observe, there's no single and universally accepted definition of issue salience in literature. Some scholars define salient policy issues as those that are prominent in citizens' minds, whereas others emphasize the degree of importance attributed to a particular issue. Beyers et al. (2018), for instance, conceptualize issue salience in terms of the importance attributed to a political matter, while Warntjen (2012) defines salience more generally as "the importance an actor attaches to an issue".

Following this conceptual tradition and consistently with the empirical operationalization adopted in this thesis, issue salience is understood as the extent to which an issue is identified by citizens as one of the most important problems facing their country. This definition aligns directly with the structure of the Eurobarometer survey items used in the empirical analysis. Accordingly, this thesis focuses specifically on terrorism issue salience, defined as the likelihood that citizens identify terrorism among the most important problems facing their country.

This likelihood, however, is not automatic. As Criado (2017) shows, the assumption that a terrorist attack straightforwardly translates into heightened issue salience holds mainly in countries where terrorist attacks are exceptional events; in democracies that have experienced domestic terrorism over extended periods, the evolution of terrorism salience depends not only on the frequency or severity of attacks, but also on the type of target chosen by terrorist groups and on the surrounding dynamics of political competition, particularly the ideological orientation of the incumbent government. This finding underscores that issue salience should not be treated as a mechanical byproduct of an attack's occurrence, but as an outcome shaped by contextual factors. This observation further motivates the empirical, rather than assumed, assessment of terrorism salience undertaken in this thesis.

1.2 The French Context: Why France Is a Critical Case

France represents a particularly relevant case for examining changes in terrorism issue salience following a major terrorist attack. The relevance of the French case rests on four interconnected considerations: the country's historical exposure to terrorism, its recent exposure to jihadist violence

prior to November 2015, existing evidence of substantial public-attention responses to terrorist attacks, and the colonial-era security narratives concerning North African and Muslim populations within which contemporary French counterterrorism politics remain embedded.

First, terrorism was not an entirely new issue for French public opinion in November 2015, when a coordinated attacks, carried out across multiple locations in Paris and Saint-Denis, including the Bataclan concert hall, killed 130 people and injured hundreds more. As reconstructed by Brouard et al. (2018), France has a long and complex history of political violence and terrorism. While the origins of the terms *terrorist* and *terrorism* can be traced back to the French Revolution and the Reign of Terror, France has subsequently experienced different forms of terrorist violence, including separatist violence, in Corsica and the Basque Country, attacks connected to international conflicts, jihadist-inspired attacks during the 1990s, and the attacks carried out by Mohammed Merah in Toulouse and Montauban in 2012. This historical experience indicates that terrorism was not an unfamiliar phenomenon within the French political and security context. At the same time, Brouard et al. (2018) emphasize that wave of attacks that affected France in 2015 and 2016 was unprecedented in its scale and symbolic significance for contemporary French society. The November 2015 attacks therefore occurred within a country familiar with terrorism as a political and security issue, while simultaneously confronting an event of expectational magnitude. The attacks, that killed 130 people and around 400 more, made them the deadliest terrorist attacks on French soil since the Second World War[1].

Second, the November attacks occurred after a period of particularly intense and highly visible exposure to Jihadist terrorism. Most notably, the attack against the offices of *Charlie Hebdo* in January 2015 had already brought terrorism to the center of public and political attention. The November attacks therefore did not occur in a context in which terrorism suddenly emerged as a new issue. As observed by de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone (2021) the attacks in Paris in January and November 2015 formed part of a broader wave of jihadist violence across Europe, including subsequent attacks in Brussels (2016), Nice (2016), Manchester (2017) and Barcelona (2017). These events generated extensive media attention and important political and policy responses across Europe, illustrating the centrality of terrorism within the European political agenda during this period. While each event generated its own attentional response, the November 2015 Paris attacks provide a particularly suitable case for the present analysis because they combined an exceptionally high level of violence with a well-established pre-existing security narrative, while Eurobarometer fieldwork

[1] Encyclopedia Britannica, “Paris attacks of 2015”, https://www.britannica.com/event/Paris-attacks-of-2015 (Last access: 28 August 2026)

was conducted in the days immediately surrounding the event. The rationale for the case selection and the broader research design is discussed in Chapter 2.

Moreover, the French case is particularly relevant not only because of its historical and recent exposure to terrorism but also because previous empirical research provides evidence of substantial public-attention responses following terrorist attacks. Nussio et al. (2021) show that terrorist attacks can produce large increase in attention to terrorism in countries directly affected by an attack. Their analysis identifies the November 2015 Paris attacks as one of the cases associated with the strongest increases in terrorism-related attention among citizens in the directly affected country. Similarly, de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone (2021) document substantial increase in the salience of terrorism in France following major terrorist attacks. This attentional shift coincided with a salient political conjuncture: the November 2015 attacks occurred three weeks before regional elections held under a state of emergency, in which the Front National recorded its strongest first-round result to date, campaigning heavily on security and immigration. This context is relevant according to Criado (2017), who finds that terrorism salience is shaped not only by the occurrence of terrorist attacks, but also by the broader dynamics of political competition and political context surrounding them. The French case represents more than a theoretically plausible setting: existing empirical evidence indicates that terrorist attacks have historically been associated with substantial changes in the extent to which French citizens identify terrorism as a major societal concern.

Finally, terrorism in France has been embedded within a broader and historically rooted debate concerning national security and the management of populations originating from former colonial territories. Benhadda (2025) provides a historical reconstruction of the relationship between security concerns and North African migration, showing that the association between North African population and questions of security did not emerge only in the contemporary period. Concerns surrounding the North African presence in France were already linked to perceptions of criminality and political threat during the early twentieth century. This historical trajectory is relevant to the contemporary French context, in which terrorism, national security, immigration, and the integration of Muslim populations have become increasingly interconnected, particularly in the context of jihadist terrorist attacks (Benhadda, 2025).

This historical embeddedness is relevant to issue salience specifically, rather than only to security politics more broadly, because it provides citizens with a pre-existing interpretive frame through which a new terrorist attack can be readily categorized. Consistent with framing theory (Entman, 1993), an attack that fits within an already established interpretative schema may register as salient

more readily than one lacking such a frame. Although developed in the context of U.S. media coverage after 9/11, Powell's (2011) analysis illustrates this same mechanism empirically. She founds a persistent media tendency to connect terrorist violence to pre-existing narratives concerning specific population groups, reinforcing rather than constructing anew the association between terrorism and a particular community. The same logic plausibly extends to the French case: as discussed in Section 1.1, an event's capacity to become salient depends in part on its ability to capture public attention within a recognizable narrative, and jihadist terrorism in France did not need to construct such a schema from scratch. It could instead draw on a security narrative concerning North African and Muslim populations that had already been consolidated over previous decades.

This historical context does not imply, however, that terrorist attacks necessarily translate into proportional changes in attitudes towards immigration or migrants. Attention to terrorism as a political issue and attitudes towards immigration policy are analytically distinct dimensions. Indeed, Brouard et al. (2018), examining the aftermath of the Paris and Nice attacks, find that their effects were concentrated primarily on security-related attitudes, with no comparable effects on attitudes towards immigration. This distinction is important for the present study, which is concerned not with whether terrorist attacks reshape attitudes towards migrants or immigration policy, but with whether they increase the salience of terrorism itself as a public issue.

Taken together, these considerations make France a particularly relevant case for studying the relationship between terrorist attacks and terrorism issue salience. The combination of France's exposure to terrorism, the documented public-attention responses to previous attacks, and the country's broader historical and political context provides both theoretical and empirical grounds to expect a substantial increase in terrorism issue salience following the November 2015 attacks.

1.3 Geographic Proximity and the Spatial Diffusion of Terrorism Effects

If terrorism functions primarily as a communicative act aimed at reaching an audience beyond its immediate victims, as discussed above, its effects should not necessarily be confined to the country directly affected by an attack. Previous research has therefore examined whether terrorist attacks can generate attitudinal and psychological spillovers across national borders and whether these effects vary according to the geographical proximity of the affected population.

A key mechanism underlying the proximity hypothesis is the perception of threat. Terrorist attacks occurring closer to individuals may generate stronger feelings of fear and imminent danger, while also receiving greater media attention in neighboring countries. Böhmelt et al. (2020) argue that these mechanisms should make terrorist attacks more consequential for populations geographically closer to the targeted country and provide direct empirical support for this claim: using spatial econometric models applied to data on terrorist attacks across Europe, they find that migration concern increases significantly more in countries sharing a border with the attacked country than in more distant ones. Evidence that terrorist attacks can produce effects beyond national borders is also provided by Legewie (2013), who examines the 2002 Bali attack and finds a significant and substantial increase in negative attitudes toward immigrants, though only in 3 of the 9 European countries examined (Portugal, Poland, and Finland). Crucially, since all nine countries were comparably distant from Bali, this heterogeneity is attributed not to geographical proximity to the attack itself, but to contextual factors such as local economic conditions and the size of the resident immigrant population. This is a first indication that proximity alone may not be the decisive factor shaping attitudinal responses to terrorism.

This ambiguity is confirmed by more direct evidence. Nussio et al. (2019) explicitly test the proximity-to-attack hypothesis in the aftermath of the November 2015 Paris attacks, examining its effects on migration attitudes across Europe. Contrary to the theoretical expectation, they find no evidence that proximity to the attack amplified the effect on migration attitudes; if anything, more negative attitudes were observed in countries farther from France. Instead, the effects were more pronounced in countries characterized by lower levels of prior immigration, suggesting that the local social and political context may be more important than geographical distance for this particular outcome.

The relevance of geographical proximity may therefore depend on the type of outcome considered. While previous studies have primarily examined migration attitudes and other downstream political preferences, terrorism issue salience captures a more immediate response to the attack itself: whether citizens identify terrorism as an important problem competing for attention with other issues. This distinction is particularly relevant considering Nussio et al. (2021), who show that terrorist attacks can substantially increase attention to terrorism and that these effects are not necessarily confined to the country directly targeted. In their analysis of the November 2015 Paris attacks, the authors compare France with the rest of Europe, providing evidence that the increase in terrorism-related attention can extend beyond the directly affected country.

The comparison between France and the rest of Europe therefore provides an important starting point for examining the spatial diffusion of terrorism-related attention. However, whether the intensity of this response varies systematically with geographical proximity, as found by Böhmelt et al. (2020) for migration concern, but not in Nussio et al. (2019) for migration attitudes remains an open question when the outcome is terrorism salience itself. This provides the basis for the more specific research gap and contribution developed in the following section.

1.4 Research Gap and Contribution

The literature reviewed above establishes two main points. First, terrorist attacks can generate substantial changes in public attention, with terrorism becoming more salient as a political issue in the aftermath of an attack. Second, these effects may extend beyond the country directly affected.

In particular, Nussio et al. (2021) provide direct evidence that terrorist attacks can increase attention to terrorism. Using an Unexpected Event during Survey Design (UESD) framework, their analysis of the November 2015 Paris attacks compares the effects of the attack in France with those observed in the rest of Europe. This approach provides an important basis for studying the cross-national diffusion of terrorism-related attention. However, the comparison between France and the rest of Europe does not explicitly distinguish between countries according to their geographical proximity to the targeted country.

This distinction is relevant according to the proximity hypothesis advanced by Böhmelt et al. (2020). Using a different empirical strategy based on spatial econometric models and conflict event data, the authors show that the effects of terrorist attacks can spill across national borders and are stronger in neighboring countries than in more distant ones. While Böhmelt et al. (2020) examine this spatial pattern using different empirical approach and outcome, their findings provide a theoretical basis for expecting geographical proximity to condition the intensity of the response to terrorist violence. However, evidence on this hypothesis in the specific context of the November 2015 Paris attacks is not unequivocal: Nussio et al. (2019) find no support for geographical proximity amplifying the effect of the attack on migration attitudes, suggesting that proximity may operate through channels other than physical distance alone.

Building on these stands of research, this thesis extends the geographical comparison within UESD framework along two dimensions. Focusing on the November 2015 Paris attacks, the analysis distinguishes between four geographical groups: France, countries sharing a border with France, the

rest of Europe excluding France and its neighboring countries, and *Previous Exposure Countries*, namely countries that had already experienced terrorist attacks before November 2015. Introducing neighboring countries as an intermediate geographical category makes it possible to examine whether the cross-national diffusion of terrorism issue salience follows a pattern consistent with geographical proximity, while introducing the *Previous Exposure Countries* group makes it possible to examine whether the diffusion of terrorism issue salience is instead conditioned by a form of experiential proximity, that is, prior exposure to terrorism, rather than by geographical closeness alone. The central research question of this thesis is therefore: does proximity to a terrorist attack, whether geographical or experiential, condition its effect on terrorism issue salience?

By translating the substantive proximity hypothesis into a UESD framework, this thesis tests whether the treatment effect follows a geographical gradient and whether it is additionally shaped by prior exposure to terrorism. If geographical proximity to the attack shapes the intensity of the response, the effect should be strongest in France, weaker among respondents in neighboring countries and smallest or absent in the rest of Europe. If experiential proximity also plays a role, the effect in *Previous Exposure Countries* should be stronger than in the rest of Europe, reflecting a heightened sensitivity to terrorism-related events among publics that have already faced such attacks.

2. Data and Research Design

2.1 The Event: The November 13, 2015, Paris Attacks

On the evening of November 13, 2015, a coordinated series of terrorist attacks struck Paris and the surrounding area of Saint-Denis. The attacks began at approximately 9:20 p.m., when a suicide bomber detonated his explosives near the Stade de France in Saint-Denis after being prevented from entering the stadium. A second suicide bomber detonated himself near the stadium approximately ten minutes later. At around 9:25 p.m., armed attackers simultaneously targeted several popular bars and restaurants in Paris's 10th and 11th arrondissements. The attack was followed by shootings at several nearby cafés and restaurants, resulting in numerous casualties. At approximately the same time, another group of attackers carried out the deadliest attack of the evening at the Bataclan, a historic concert hall located on Boulevard Voltaire. During a concert, the attackers opened fire on the audience and subsequently took hostages. The siege lasted for more than two hours and ended shortly after midnight, when French security forces stormed the building.

While the hostage crisis at the Bataclan was still ongoing, President François Hollande declared a state of emergency across France. On November 14, the Islamic State (ISIS) claimed responsibility for the attacks, describing them as the beginning of "the storm". Hollande subsequently characterized the attacks as an "act of war" and declared three days of national mourning. In the following days, French police also carried out hundreds of raids across the country as part of the investigation and security response.

The coordinated attacks resulted in 130 deaths and hundreds of injuries, making them one of the deadliest terrorist attacks on French soil in recent history, with a major impact on public debate in France and across Europe, particularly regarding terrorism, national security and immigration.

On November 15, French warplanes launched a series of airstrikes against targets in Raqqa, Syria, the de facto capital of the Islamic State at the time, representing a significant escalation of France's military intervention in the Syrian conflict and a direct external response to the Paris attacks.

These two responses – the declaration of the state of emergency and the airstrikes on Raqqa – are treated in this thesis as collateral events triggered by the attacks. As discussed in Chapter 3, in relation to identifying assumption of the UESD framework, such collateral responses do not necessarily undermine the internal validity of the research design.

This reconstruction of the timeline and of the political and military response is based on the historical account provided by *Encyclopedia Britannica*[2].

2.2 Data: Standard Eurobarometer 84.3

The data used in this study are drawn from Standard Eurobarometer 84.3, fielded between 7 and 17 November 2015 and obtained from the GESIS Data Archive for Social Sciences. Eurobarometer is the European Union's official public opinion survey programme; established in 1974, it is regularly conducted on behalf of the European Parliament, the European Commission, and other EU institutions to monitor citizens' opinions on EU-related issues as well as broad range of political and social topics[3].

Since the Paris attacks took place on 13 November 2015, precisely during the fieldwork of Eurobarometer 84.3, the survey offers a unique opportunity to exploit the occurrence of an unexpected event while interviews were still being conducted, comparing respondents interviewed before and after the attacks to identify the causal impact of the event on public attitudes.

Figure 1 shows the fieldwork period of Eurobarometer 84.3 by participating country; the red dashed line marks the date of the attacks (13 November 2015). As the figure shows, the attacks occurred while the survey was still in progress in most countries, meaning that respondents were interviewed both before and after the event. This overlap constitutes the empirical basis for the identification strategy adopted in this study.

[2] Encyclopedia Britannica, "Paris attacks of 2015", https://www.britannica.com/event/Paris-attacks-of-2015 (Last access: 28 August 2026)
[3] European Parliament, "Eurobarometer", https://www.europarl.europa.eu/at-your-service/it/be-heard/eurobarometer (Last access: 28 August 2026)

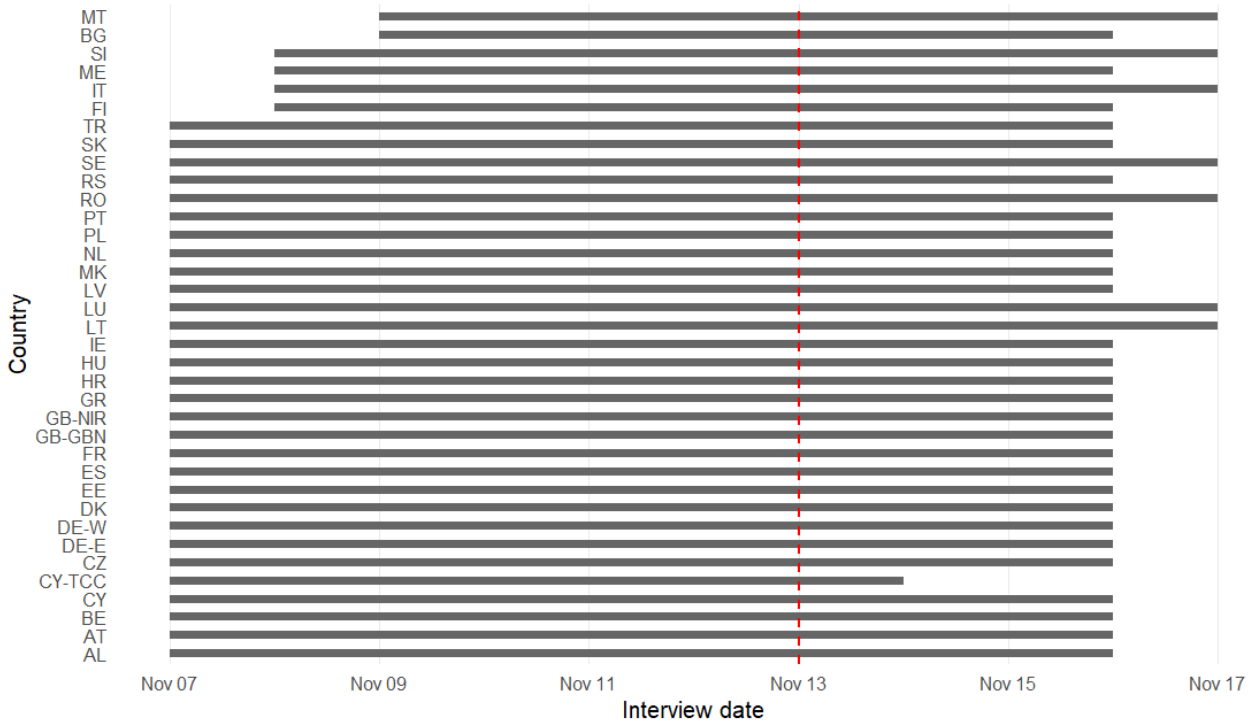


Figure 1. Fieldwork period of Eurobarometer 84.3 by country

2.3 Research Design: The Unexpected Event during Survey Design (UESD)

To estimate the causal effect of the 13 November 2015 Paris terrorist attacks on Terrorism Salience, this thesis adopts the Unexpected Event during Survey Design (UESD) as systemized by Muñoz et al. (2020). This research design exploits the occurrence of an unexpected event during the fieldwork of a public opinion survey to estimate its causal effect on a relevant outcome, by comparing the responses of individuals interviewed before the event with those interviewed after the event.

This identification strategy relies on the assumption that the timing of respondents' interviews during the survey fieldwork is independent of the occurrence of the unexpected event. Consequently, assignment to the treatment or control group is considered as good as random, allowing any systematic differences in outcomes between the two groups to be causally attributed to the event itself. The validity of this identification strategy, however, depends on this assumption, together with the other conditions required for the UESD design, being satisfied.

This identification strategy is particularly well suited to the present study for three reasons. First, terrorist attack constitutes the type of event most frequently analyzed through this design in the existing literature. Because they cannot be directly manipulated through controlled experiments,

researchers have widely adopted the UESD as a quasi-experimental design to estimate their causal effects across a broad range of outcomes and contexts. For instance, Dinesen & Jæger (2013) exploit the 2004 Madrid train bombings to estimate their effect on institutional trust, while Finseraas & Listhaug (2013) use the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks to examine shifts in public opinion across several Western European countries. Other studies in this tradition have similarly relied on terrorist attacks occurring during ongoing survey fieldwork to identify their causal effects on political attitudes, trust, and electoral behavior (Muñoz et al., 2020). Second, the event examined occurred during the fieldwork of Eurobarometer 84.3, which was conducted between 7 and 17 November 2015, making it possible to compare respondents interviewed before and after the attacks within the same survey. Third, unlike longitudinal or repeated cross-sectional designs, the UESD identifies the effect of the event using a single survey conducted over a short period of time. Because all respondents answer the same questionnaire under the same survey conditions, the design minimizes the risk that changes unrelated to the terrorist attacks, such as political, economic, or social developments, drive the estimated effect.

Building on this design, the analysis further exploits geographic variation by comparing three subsamples: France, countries sharing a border with France, and the rest of Europe. As discussed in Chapter 1, this three-group design extends the comparison adopted by Nussio et al. (2021), who contrast the effect of the attack in the targeted country against the rest of Europe within the same UESD framework. The introduction of an intermediate group of bordering countries, allows a direct test of the proximity hypothesis advanced by Böhmelt et al. (2020). If geographic proximity to the attacks shapes the intensity of the effect, the treatment effect should decrease gradually from France, to bordering countries, to the rest of Europe. Moreover, drawing on the findings of Nussio et al. (2019), the analysis introduces a fourth subsample, composed of *Previous Exposure Countries*. This group allows the proximity hypothesis to be tested along a second, non-geographic dimension: rather than physical distance, prior exposure captures a form of experiential or perceptual proximity to terrorism, which may shape how strongly a country's public reacts to a new attack elsewhere.

Comparing the treatment effects across these four samples makes it possible to assess whether reactions to the Paris attacks are driven primarily by geographical closeness, prior experience with terrorism, or a combination of both.

2.4 Sample Definition

To assess the extent and geographical scope of the effect of the Paris terrorist attacks on terrorism salience, the analysis is conducted separately on three samples. *France*, the country directly affected by the attacks, represents the primary sample and allows for the estimation of the effect among individuals directly exposed to the event. The *Rest of Europe* (ROE), excluding France and the countries sharing a land border with France, is examined to assess whether changes in terrorism issue salience extended to geographically more distant European countries. *Neighboring Countries* – Belgium, Germany, Luxembourg, Spain and Italy – are analyzed separately as a geographically proximate group. This intermediate category extends the comparison between France and the broader European sample adopted by Nussio et al. (2021) and allows for an assessment of whether the effects of the attacks were more pronounced in countries geographically close to France. These three samples are mutually exclusive. Together, they allow the analysis to distinguish between the country directly affected by the attacks, geographically neighboring countries, and the remaining, more distant European countries. This geographical classification provides the basis for examining whether the effects of the attacks vary systematically according to geographical proximity.

To capture not only geographic proximity but also the role of previous exposure to terrorism, a fourth sample is constructed: *Previous Exposure Countries* (PEC), composed of countries that had already experienced at least one terrorist attack before the Paris attacks, regardless of the ideological motivation behind it. Unlike the first three samples, the PEC sample is not defined by geographical criteria and therefore is not mutually exclusive with them, as it may include countries already classified as neighboring or as part of the rest of Europe. The rationale for this classification is to examine whether respondents in countries with prior experience of terrorism react differently to a new terrorist event elsewhere, reflecting not geographical proximity but a broader familiarity with the threat shaped by national context. Considering a relatively broad time window from 2000 to 13 November 2015, the countries identified were Spain, the United Kingdom, Germany, Belgium, Bulgaria, Denmark, and the Netherlands. A detailed overview of the selected countries and the corresponding terrorist attacks is provided in the Appendix A.

Consistent with the sample selection adopted in the empirical analysis, countries and territories are included in the European samples only when observations are available on both sides of the event date within the selected study period. This ensures that each geographical sample contains respondents interviewed both before and after the attacks.

2.5 Treatment and Control Group Definition

To estimate the causal effect of the attacks, respondents interviewed within a narrow time window surrounding the event are compared. Restricting the analysis to a short period minimizes the likelihood that changes in public opinion are driven by unrelated temporal trends rather than by the terrorist attacks themselves (Nussio et al., 2019).

Following Balcells & Torrats-Espinosa (2018), a 3-day window around the event was adopted, excluding interviews conducted on 13 November 2015, the day of the attacks, since respondents interviewed on that date may have been surveyed either before or after the attacks occurred, making their treatment status unclassifiable (Nussio et al., 2019). Balcells & Torrats-Espinosa (2018) show that estimated effects remain stable across alternative short time windows, supporting the use of a 3-day window while ensuring comparability with the existing literature.

Figure 2 illustrates the daily number of survey respondents interviewed in France during the fieldwork period surrounding the attacks and visually represents the construction of the treatment and control groups. The x-axis reports the interview date, while the y-axis shows the number of respondents interviewed each day; the dashed vertical line marks the day of the attacks. Consistent with the research design, interviews conducted on that day are excluded from the analysis. The figure also shows a gradual decline in fieldwork activity toward the end of the survey period; as a result, the treatment group contains substantially fewer observations (N = 97) than the control group (N = 421). This imbalance should be acknowledged as a limitation of the research design, as the smaller post-attack sample may reduce the statistical power and precision of the estimated treatment effects in France.

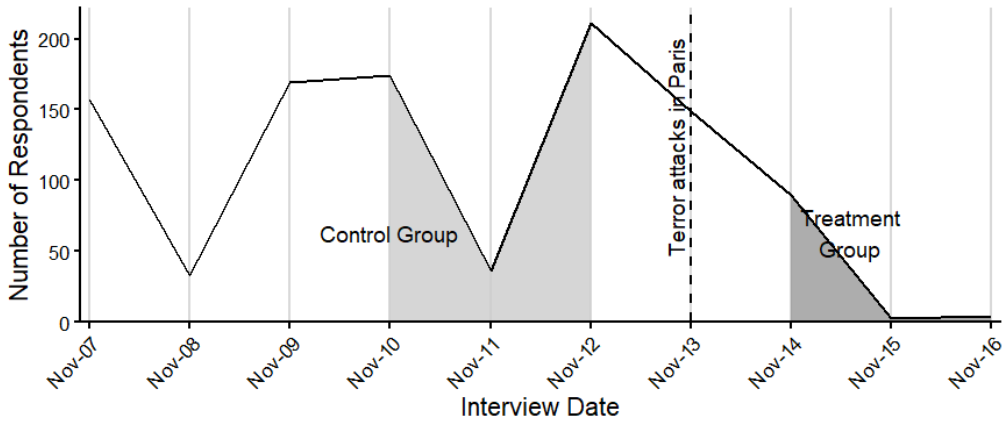


Figure 2. Treatment and Control Groups in France

The same procedure is applied to construct the treatment and control groups for the other three samples. The daily distribution of interviews for each of the three samples is reported in Appendix B, together with the resulting composition of the treatment and control groups in terms of observations. The same procedure is also used to construct the treatment and control groups under the narrower ±1-day window employed in the robustness checks presented in Section 4.3.1; the resulting sample composition for this alternative bandwidth is likewise reported in Appendix B.

2.6 Variables

2.6.1 Dependent Variable

Following Nussio et al. (2021) the main dependent variable in this study is *Terrorism Salience*, constructed from the Eurobarometer question QA3a: "What do you think are the two most important issues facing (OUR COUNTRY) at the moment?" The variable is coded as 1 if the respondent mentions terrorism as one of the two most important issues and 0 otherwise. This measure captures whether terrorism occupied a prominent position in respondents' perceived issue agenda.

2.6.2 Treatment Variables

As specified in the research design, treatment assignment is based on the timing of the interview relative to the attacks: respondents interviewed before the event form the control group, and respondents interviewed afterwards form the treatment group (Nussio et al., 2021). Accordingly, a binary indicator, *Treatment*, is constructed, equal to 1 for respondents interviewed after the attacks, and 0 otherwise. Since the attacks occurred unexpectedly during the survey fieldwork, respondents could not self-select into either group, making treatment assignment plausibly exogenous. As noted above, interviews conducted on the day of the attacks are excluded to avoid misclassification (Nussio et al., 2019).

2.6.3 Control Variables

Although the timing of the attacks is plausibly exogenous to respondents' characteristics, a set of socio-demographic controls is included, all drawn from the Eurobarometer 84.3 survey to account for any residual differences in sample composition between respondents interviewed before and after the

event and to improve the precision of the estimates. As recommended in the UESD literature (Balcells & Torrats-Espinosa, 2018; Muñoz et al., 2020; Nussio et al., 2021), the inclusion of observable covariates helps account for any remaining imbalance between the pre and post attacks samples, thereby strengthening the credibility of the empirical analysis.

Four control variables are included: respondents' age, gender, area of residence and current occupation. First, respondents' age is captured through the variable *Age*, measured in years and ranging between 15 and 99 in the sample, reflecting a broad age distribution. Second, gender is capture through a dummy variable, *Female*, equal to 1 if the respondent is female and 0 otherwise (53.5% of the sample). Third, respondents' place of residence is captured through a dummy variable, *Rural*, equal to 1 if the respondent lives in a rural area, 0 otherwise (30.2% of the sample). Finally, respondents' current occupation is captured through the variable *Occupation*: the original Eurobarometer variable is recoded into four categories – retired, student, unemployed, and worker – with workers constituting the largest group (54.3%). This reclassification captures differences in labor market status while maintaining a parsimonious model specification. A full description and descriptive statistics of these variables are reported in Appendix C.

2.7 Descriptive Evidence

As a preliminary step, this section presents descriptive evidence on the main dependent variable, before turning to the empirical analysis. Two perspectives are considered: first, a simple before-after comparison of terrorism salience across the samples, and, in greater detail, within France; second, a cross-sectional breakdown of terrorism salience by socio-demographic characteristics, aimed at describing the composition of the sample rather than identifying any causal pattern.

Table 1 reports a simple before-after comparison of terrorism salience across the four samples used in the analysis. For each sample, the *before attacks* includes respondents interviewed between November 10 and November 12, 2015, while the *after attack*s group includes respondents interviewed between November 14 and November 16, 2015; interviews conducted on November 13, 2015, are excluded from both groups.

Terrorism salience increased substantially in France following the attacks. A much smaller increase is observed in the other three samples. Notably, although the increase is marginally smaller in the neighboring countries than in the rest of Europe, the level of terrorism salience is consistently higher in the neighboring countries both before and after the attacks. Thus, at this purely descriptive stage,

geographic proximity to France does not appear to translate into a systematically stronger increase in terrorism salience among bordering countries relative to the rest of the continent. Rather, neighboring countries exhibit a higher baseline level of terrorism salience, which persists after the attacks. The PEC sample displays somewhat different patterns. Its baseline level of terrorism salience before the attacks is very close to that of the neighboring countries and slightly higher than that of the rest of Europe, yet its post-attack increase is the largest among the three non-French samples, exceeding both. At this descriptive stage, this suggests that prior national experience with terrorism may be associated with a stronger reaction to a new attack elsewhere, even in the absence of geographic proximity to France.

Sample	***Group***	***Respondents (N)***	***Terrorism salience (%)***	***Difference (p.p)***
France	Before attacks	421	15.90	+35.60
	After attacks	97	51.50	
Rest of Europe	Before attacks	9,231	5.46	+5.64
	After attacks	7,280	11.10	
Neighboring countries	Before attacks	1,975	6.58	+5.22
	After attacks	923	11.80	
Previous Exposure Countries	Before attacks	2,633	6.57	+9.13
	After attacks	1,432	15.70	

Table 1. Terrorism Salience Before and After the Paris Attacks by Sample

Given the scale of the increase observe in France, it is useful to examine more closely what this shift in terrorism salience displaced within the national issue agenda. Figure 3 provides a broader descriptive picture of issue salience in France before and after the attacks. While several issues show relatively modest changes, terrorism stands out as the issue experiencing by far the largest increase, rising from 15.9% to 51.5%. Notably, this increase coincides with a marked decline in the salience of unemployment, which falls from 54.2% to 42.3%.

This pattern is consistent with the killer issue dynamic discusses in Chapter 1: as terrorism suddenly captured public attention, it appears to have displaced unemployment as the dominant concern, rather than simply adding to an unchanged agenda (Brosius and Kepplinger, 1995). This displacement is particularly notable given that unemployment was, at the time, an especially salient structural issue in France. In the third quarter of 2015 the unemployment rate in metropolitan France stood at 10.2% of the active population, having risen by 0.2 percentage points both quarter-on-quarter and year-on-

year, with the total number of unemployed reaching 2.9 million[4]. The sharp drop in its salience immediately after the attacks is therefore unlikely to reflect any actual improvement in economic conditions and is better interpreted as evidence of attentional displacement: a fixed amount of public attention being reallocated toward terrorism (Zhu, 1992). This descriptive pattern is consistent with the expectation that a major terrorist attack can temporarily elevate terrorism on the public agenda, although, being purely descriptive, it does not by itself establish a causal effect.

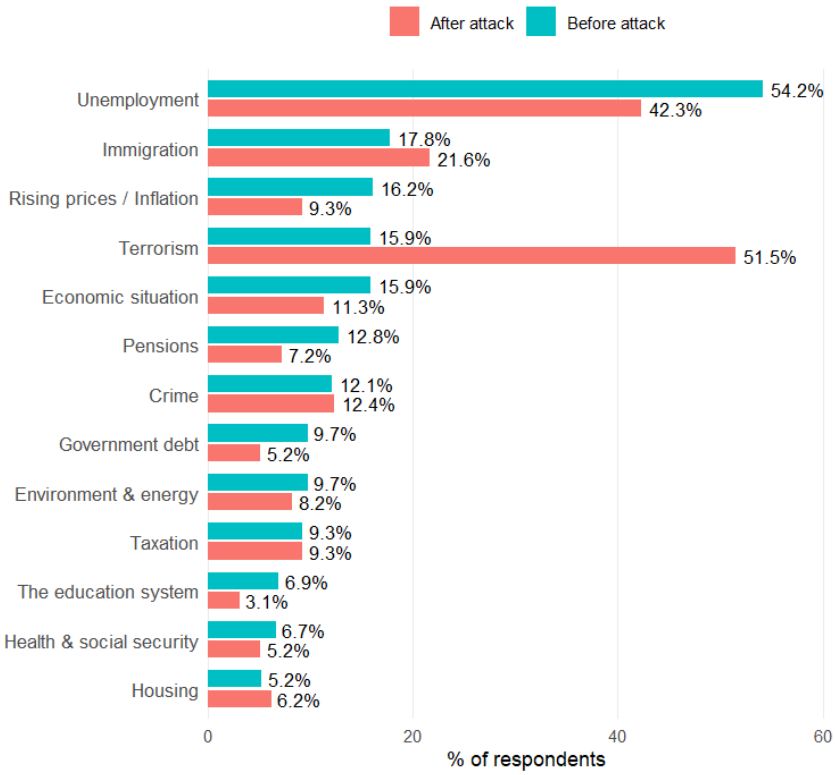


Figure 3. Most Important Issues Facing France Before and After the Event

The second perspective examines how terrorism salience varies across socio-demographic groups. Table 2 presents descriptive statistics for the full Eurobarometer 84.3 sample. Overall, differences in terrorism salience across most groups are relatively small. Male respondents are slightly more likely than female respondents to identify terrorism as one of the country's two most important issues, with a difference of 0.6 percentage points. Similarly, differences between respondents living in urban areas (8.0%) and those living in rural areas (7.0%) are modest. In contrast, occupational status appears to

[4] Insee (Institut national de la statistique et des études économiques), "Increase in the unemployment rate in Q3 2015", https://www.insee.fr/en/statistiques/1565161 (Last access: 28 August 2026)

be the most strongly associated characteristic with terrorism salience: respondents with stronger labor market attachment are more likely to report terrorism as one of the country's two most important issues, with workers showing the highest share (8.6%) and unemployed the lowest (5.1%).

Variable	***Group***	***N***	***Terrorism = 1 (N)***	***Share (%)***
Occupation	Retired	9,647	662	6.9
	Student	2,296	175	7.6
	Unemployed	3,050	156	5.1
	Workers	17,840	1,540	8.6
Female	Male	15,281	1,229	8.0
Female	Female	17,552	1,304	7.4
Rural	Urban/Town	22,900	1,839	8.0
Rural	Rural	9,903	692	7.0

Table 2. Descriptive Statistics: Terrorism Salience by Socio-Demographic Characteristics

3. Identifying Assumptions of the UESD

3.1 Overview of the Identifying Assumptions of the UESD

According to Muñoz et al. (2020), the validity of causal estimates derived from the UESD rests on several identifying assumptions: *excludability* and (temporal*) ignorability* are the main ones. Excludability requires that the timing of the survey interview affects the outcome variable only through exposure to the event, and not through any other collateral, simultaneous or time-trending factor correlated with the timing of the interview. Ignorability requires that the moment at which each respondent was interviewed is independent of their potential outcomes, so that assignment to the pre- and post-event subsamples can be treated as good as random.

In addition to these two core assumptions, the validity of UESD estimates may be threatened by *noncompliance, heterogeneous treatment effects and posttreatment bias.* Noncompliance arises when respondents interviewed after the event are not necessarily exposed to the event, while heterogeneous treatment effects refer to the possibility that the effect of the event varies across individuals or subgroups. Finally, posttreatment bias may arise when analyses condition on variables that are themselves affected by the event, potentially introducing bias into the estimated treatment effect.

The UESD does not guarantee that these conditions hold by design. Rather, their plausibility must be empirically assessed and, where necessary, addressed through appropriate estimation strategies and robustness checks. Before presenting the empirical analysis, each identifying assumption will be discussed in turn, highlighting the potential threats to its validity and the strategies adopted to address them.

3.2 Excludability

Following Muñoz et al. (2020), excludability can be violated by three main threats. First, *collateral events*: the reactions triggered by the attacks itself, such as the French state of emergency, the temporary closure of Schengen borders, and the subsequent military response, may mean that any estimated effect reflects the joint impact of the attack and these reactions, rather than the attack alone. Second, *simultaneous events* unrelated to the attack may covary with the timing of the interview. The most relevant candidate here is the ongoing European migration crisis, which was already high salient

in November 2015. Third, *unrelated time trends* could bias the estimates if terrorism salience was already on an upward trajectory before 13 November 2015 for reasons unconnected to the attack.

Endogenous timing of the event is not a serious concern in this application, since the date of a terrorist attacks is not plausibly chosen in anticipation of, or in coordination with, the Eurobarometer fieldwork calendar.

Excludability will be assessed through an in-depth qualitative reconstruction of the political context surrounding the terrorist attacks to evaluate the salience of potential competing events, such as the European migration crisis. In addition, pre-existing time trends will be inspected by splitting the pre-event control group at its empirical median and testing for differences between the two pre-treatment subsamples.

3.2.1 Event and Survey Characterization

Understanding how the survey was conducted is essential to assess both the ignorability and excludability assumptions of the UESD (Muñoz et al., 2020). This section describes the relevant methodological features of Eurobarometer 84.3 (GESIS Study No. ZA6643), drawing on the corresponding GESIS Variable Report (GESIS Variable Reports No. 2019|2, doi: 10.4232/1.13249).

Fieldwork and mode of administration. Eurobarometer 84.3 fieldwork was carried out by TNS Opinion & Social at the request of the European Commission. In all participating countries, fieldwork was conducted face-to-face in respondents' homes, in the respective national language. As far as data capture is concerned, Computer-Assisted Personal Interviewing (CAPI) was used in those countries where this technique was available, which included France. Interviews were conducted between November 7 and November 17, 2015.

Sampling design. The basic sampling design applied in all states is a multi-stage, random probability design. Sampling points are selected through random selection after stratification by the distribution of the national resident population across metropolitan, urban, and rural areas, that is, proportional to population size and population density. These primary sampling units (PSUs) are drawn systematically from each of the administrative regions in every country, following the EUROSTAT NUTS classification.

Relevance for the ignorability assumption. Muñoz et al. (2020) emphasize that particular attention should be paid to the sampling procedure, the procedures used to contact sampled units, and the strategy for dealing with unit nonresponse, noting that quota sampling can threaten the ignorability

assumption: interviewers tend to complete easier-to-reach quotas earlier in the fieldwork, which creates a systematic link between interview timing and respondent characteristics. The Eurobarometer, however, does not use quota sampling. It relies instead on a purely probabilistic design, in which responders are selected at random rather than chosen by interviewers to fill demographics targets. This makes it comparatively less exposed to the risk described above and supports the plausibility of as-if random assignment based on interview timing. However, this does not guarantee full ignorability on its own, which is why it needs to be tested empirically through balance tests.

Disruptive events and fieldwork continuity. Muñoz et al. (2020) also recommend checking whether the event itself disrupted the fieldwork; for example, through a temporary suspension of data collection. No evidence of this was found in the GESIS report for France. However, the attacks occurred close to the end of the French fieldwork period (November 13, within a November 7–17 window), leaving only a small number of interviews after the event. This limits the statistical power of the treatment group and motivates the multiple-bandwidth robustness checks.

3.2.2 Collateral Events

As anticipated in Chapter 2.1, the declaration of the state of emergency and the airstrikes on Raqqa are treated in this thesis as collateral events triggered by the attacks. These collateral events are important for the empirical analysis because they occurred immediately after the terrorist attacks and may themselves have affected respondents' perceptions of terrorism, security, or national institutions. Consequently, any observed change in the outcomes following November 13 cannot necessarily be attributed exclusively to the attacks if respondents were also exposed to these subsequent developments.

Following Muñoz et al. (2020), this configuration can be understood as a case of *imprecise treatment*, since the treatment cannot be cleanly separated into the initial terrorist attack and the immediate response that followed it. The estimated treatment effect should therefore be interpreted as capturing the overall effect of the attack and its immediate aftermath, rather than the isolated causal effect of the attack itself.

This does not necessarily undermine the internal validity of the UESD design. If the institutional and military responses are themselves an expected and constitutive part of the response to a major terrorist attack, they can reasonably be considered part of the treatment exposure generated by the event.

However, this interpretation introduces an important external validity and generalizability concern. The estimated effect may not readily generalize to terrorist attacks of different types or scales, particularly when such attacks generate substantially different institutional, political, or military responses. In other words, the effect identified by the UESD may reflect not only how individuals react to terrorist violence itself, but also how that violence is subsequently framed and addressed by political and security institutions.

3.2.3 Simultaneous Events: The European Migrant Crisis

The European migrant crisis was already unfolding in 2015 and represent an important political issue across Europe at the time of the attacks. By the autumn of 2015, Europe was experiencing the largest movement of refugees and migrants into the continent since the Second World War. According to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), more than 800,000 refugees and migrants had arrived in Europe by sea between January and mid-November 2015. Approximately 84% of these arrivals originated from five main refugee-producing countries: Syria, Afghanistan, Iraq, Eritrea, and Somalia. Many of these countries were affected by armed conflict, political instability, or severe human rights violations[5]. The migration crisis therefore constituted an important contemporaneous political context surrounding the Paris attacks and could therefore represent a competing source of variation in respondent's attitudes during the period of the study. Moreover, migration has become an active area of European policymaking immediately before the terrorist attacks. In particular, the *Valletta Summit on Migration*, held on 11-12 November 2015, brought together European and African heads of state and government to address the ongoing migration crisis. The summit resulted in the adoption of a political declaration and an action plan covering the root causes of irregular migration and forced displacement, legal migration and mobility, the protection of migrants and asylum seekers, and measures to prevent irregular migration and human trafficking [6].

The timing of the summit is particularly relevant for the present analysis, as it took place one day before the Paris attacks. Therefore, respondents interviewed shortly before November 13 could have been exposed to heightened political and media attention surrounding migration, while respondents interviewed after the attacks were exposed to both the migration-related developments and the terrorist attacks themselves. The Valletta summit consequently represents a potentially relevant

[5] Judith Sunderland, "Europe's Refugee Crisis: An Agenda for Action", Human Rights Watch, 16 November 2015, https://www.hrw.org/report/2015/11/16/europes-refugee-crisis/agenda-action (Last access: 28 August 2026)
[6] Council of the European Union / European Council, "Valletta Summit on Migration, 11-12 November 2015", https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/meetings/international-summit/2015/11/11-12/ (Last access: 28 August 2026)

contemporaneous event within the fieldwork period. The following paragraphs assess this threat empirically.

Assessment of Potential Concurrent Events. Crucially for the assessment of the excludability assumption, the salience of immigration as a political issue during the Eurobarometer fieldwork period surrounding the attacks is examined. The analysis relies on question QA3a - "What do you think are the two most important issues facing (OUR COUNTRY) at the moment?" - focusing specifically on the two response categories most relevant to this study: *terrorism* and *immigration*. A ±3-day bandwidth around the event date (November 10–16, excluding November 13 itself) is adopted, and the percentage of respondents mentioning each issue before and after the attacks is compared.

Focusing on the French sample, the share of respondents citing terrorism as one of the most important issues rose from 15.9% before the attack to 51.5% after. The day-by-day breakdown in Figure 4 shows a sharp increase beginning the day after the attack, peaking above 70% on November 15, before declining the day after. Note that this drop most likely reflects the small number of respondents interviewed on that specific day (N = 4) rather than a genuine dissipation of the effect and should therefore be interpreted with caution. By contrast, the share of respondents citing immigration as a top issue increased only modestly over the same window, from 17.8% before the attacks to 21.6%. Although this is a small increase, it is much smaller than the more than threefold increase observed for terrorism, suggesting that the salience of immigration remained relatively stable around the event date.

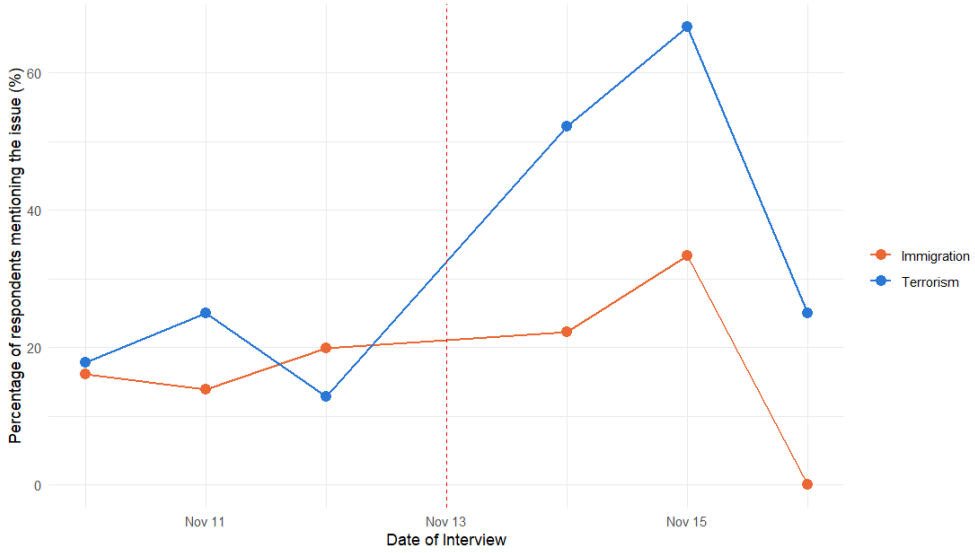


Figure 4. Daily Share of Respondents Mentioning Terrorism and Immigration (France)

To formally assess this pattern, a series of logistic regressions is estimated separately for each sample, using terrorism salience and immigration salience, in turn, as dependent variables and the post-attack treatment indicator as the main explanatory variable. The estimated treatment effects are reported in Table D1 in Appendix D, together with the corresponding daily trend graphs for the neighboring countries, the rest of Europe and PEC samples.

In France the attacks are associated with a large and highly significant increase in terrorism salience, while the corresponding effect on immigration salience is small and statistically not significant. This pattern supports the interpretation that the increase in issue salience following November 13 was specific to terrorism, rather than reflecting a broader shift in the political agenda linked to the concurrent migration debate, thereby providing reassurance for the excludability of the French estimate.

The picture is different in the other three samples. Although terrorism salience increases significantly after the attacks, immigration salience decreases significantly over the same period. This negative relationship is consistent with a displacement mechanism rather than a genuine excludability violation. As discussed in Chapter 1, terrorism has been characterized as "killer issue" capable of rapidly capturing public attention to expense of competing concerns (Hans-Bernd & Mathias Hans, 1995). Under this interpretation, the decline in immigration salience outside France would reflect a consequence of the same treatment: the increased prominence of terrorism on public agenda, rather than an independent, confounding shock originated from the migration crisis. Overall, these findings provide supporting evidence for the plausibility of the excludability assumptions.

3.2.4 Unrelated Time Trends

A further threat to the excludability assumption arises from the presence of unrelated time trends, that is, systematic variation in the outcome over the course of the fieldwork that is unrelated to the terrorist attack (Muñoz et al., 2020). To assess the plausibility of this assumption, the presence of a discontinuity in terrorism salience at an arbitrary point before the actual event is tested, following an approach developed in the regression discontinuity design (RDD) literature.

Imbens & Lemieux (2008) propose testing for discontinuities at non-cutoff points as a diagnostic for the credibility of an RDD. Since no effect is expected away from the true cutoff, finding a significant jump at an arbitrary point within one side of the sample would cast doubt on the identification strategy. Specifically, they recommend splitting each subsample – the one below and the one above the true

cutoff – at its empirical median, and testing for a discontinuity at that point, noting that splitting at the median maximizes the power of the test while relying exclusively on the subsample where no jump is expected to occur. Muñoz et al. (2020) adapt this logic directly to the UESD framework, recommending that the control group be split at its empirical median and tested for the absence of an effect at this placebo cutoff.

Following this approach, the sample of respondents interviewed before November 13 is restricted separately for each of the four geographic samples, and the empirical median of the pre-event interview-date distribution is selected as the placebo cutoff in each case. A placebo treatment indicator is then constructed, coded as 0 for respondents interviewed on or before the median date and as 1 for those interviewed afterward; both groups are entirely composed of respondents interviewed before the actual attacks, so no genuine treatment effect should be present at this cutoff. A logistic regression of terrorism salience on the placebo treatment indicator is estimated for each sample. The distribution of pre-event interviews underlying the placebo cutoff for each sample per date is reported in Appendix B, Table B1.

As shown in Table 3, the placebo test provides no evidence of a discontinuity in terrorism salience for France, the neighboring countries, or the PEC samples. The placebo treatment coefficient is small and not statistically significant in both samples. For the rest of Europe sample, by contrast, the placebo coefficient is negative and statistically significant, indicating a pre-existing downward trend in terrorism salience before the attacks. Given the considerably larger sample size in this group, this result should be interpreted with some caution, as even modest underlying trends can reach statistical significance in large samples (Muñoz et al., 2020). Moreover, since the coefficient is negative while the main hypothesis predicts an increase in terrorism salience following the attacks, this pre-existing trend runs counter to, rather than in support of, the expected treatment effect: if anything, the downward pre-event trend implies that, absent the attacks, terrorism salience may have continued to decline, suggesting that the estimated post-attack increase should be interpreted as a conservative estimate of the effect of the attacks.

Sample	***N***	***Placebo Treatment Coefficient***	***Std. Error***	***p-value***
France	780	-0.019	0.218	0.928
Neighboring Countries	3,479	-0.193	0.144	0.180
Rest of Europe	15,770	-0.279***	0.070	< 0.001
Previous Exposure Countries	4,568	-0.158	0.123	0.197

Table 3. Placebo Tests for Pre-Event Discontinuity in Terrorism Salience, by Sample

The results overall support the plausibility of the identifying assumptions underlying the UESD design for France and neighboring countries. They suggest that the sharp increase in terrorism salience observed after the November 13 attacks in these two samples is unlikely to be driven by a pre-existing discontinuity in the outcome during the pre-event fieldwork period, consistent with the results expected under the UESD framework proposed by Muñoz et al. (2020). For the rest of Europe sample, some caution is warranted, though the direction of the pre-existing trend does not undermine the interpretation of the main treatment effect as evidence of a genuine post-attack increase in salience.

3.3 Ignorability

Regarding the ignorability assumption, the main threats stem from the organization of the Eurobarometer fieldwork. In particular, the fieldwork may generate *imbalances on observable* characteristics if interviews are conducted sequentially rather than randomly. For example, in face-to-face surveys, interviews often follow a geographical pattern for efficiency reasons, with interviewers completing one area before moving to the next. If respondents' location is correlated with the timing of the interview, treatment status may also be correlated with observable characteristics that affect the outcome, thus violating the ignorability assumption. To address this concern, the *Conditional Ignorability Assumption* is adopted, according to which treatment status is independent of individuals' potential outcomes conditional on a set of observed covariates.

A related concern is *differential reachability*, which may generate imbalances in unobservable characteristics. Respondents who are harder to contact are more likely to be interviewed later in the fieldwork period and, therefore, have a higher probability of being assigned to the treatment group. If reachability is correlated with the outcome, the estimated treatment effect may be biased. This concern is mitigated by restricting the analysis to a short observation window and by assessing the

balance of observable pretreatment characteristics across the treatment and control groups, which increases the plausibility that the two groups are comparable.

Finally, *attrition* may pose a threat if the terrorist attacks themselves altered respondents' willingness to answer questions on terrorism or to participate in the survey altogether. In this case, differential nonresponse between the pre- and post-event subsamples could bias the estimated treatment effect.

To address these threats, the empirical strategy follows the sequence of best practices proposed by Muñoz et al. (2020). Ignorability is assessed through balance tests on pretreatment sociodemographic covariates across the pre- and post-event subsamples, the use of multiple bandwidths around November 13 to evaluate the trade-off between the plausibility of as-if random assignment and statistical power; and, where imbalances emerge, covariate adjustment via entropy balancing (Hainmueller, 2012), restricted to pretreatment covariates to avoid post-treatment bias.

3.3.1 Balance Tests

Methodology. Following Muñoz et al. (2020), the ignorability assumption is assessed by examining the balance of pretreatment covariates across the treatment and control groups, comparing them on the set of sociodemographic characteristics defined in Section 2.6.3, separately for each of the four geographic samples. The same three-day time window used throughout the main analysis is employed for balance tests.

For continuous covariates, a two-sample Welch t-test is used to assess whether the mean of each variable differs between the treatment and control groups:

$$H_0: E[Age|T = 1] = E[Age|T = 0] \quad (1)$$

For binary covariates, the same mean-comparison framework is applied to the 0–1 coded variables; since the mean of a binary variable corresponds to the proportion of observations coded as one, this is equivalent to testing for differences in proportions. For the categorical covariate with more than two categories (current occupation), Pearson's chi-square test of independence is used instead, evaluating whether the observed distribution of respondents across categories differs from the distribution expected under statistical independence between treatment assignment and occupation (McHugh, 2013). Together, these tests provide a preliminary assessment of whether the treatment and control groups are balanced with respect to observed pretreatment covariates, as required for assessing the plausibility of the temporal ignorability assumption (Austin, 2009).

In each case, the null hypothesis is that the covariate is balanced across the pre- and post- event subsamples. A p-value below the conventional threshold of 0.05 is taken as evidence against this null hypothesis, while a p-value above 0.05 means it cannot be rejected. Following *the American Statistical Association*'s official statement on the use and interpretation of p-values (Wasserstein & Lazar, 2016) it is important to stress that p-value does not measure the probability that the null hypothesis is true, nor the size or substantive importance of a difference between groups: a statistically significant result may correspond to a substantively negligible difference, and vice versa. This caveat applies equally to the chi-square test, which is additionally sensitive to sample size: in large samples, even small percentage differences between cells can produce very small p-value. As McHugh (2013) notes, a statistically significant chi-square result only indicates that some association exists between the two variables; it does not by itself indicate which categories are driving the difference or how strong the association is. Results for occupation are therefore reported alongside category-specific percentages, to allow a fuller interpretation of where imbalances, if any, are concentrated.

Results. Table 4 reports balance tests for pretreatment covariates in the French sample. Overall, the treatment and control groups appear well balanced across the observed characteristics. Although the treatment group is slightly younger on average, and some variation is observed across occupation categories, none of the differences is statistically significant. These results provide support for the temporal ignorability assumption, suggesting that respondents interviewed before and after the attacks do not differ systematically in their observed sociodemographic characteristics.

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	53.26 (19.6)	50.24 (19.5)	+3.02	0.171
Female, %	48.45	49.48	-1.02 pp	0.856
Rural, %	17.14	20.83	-3.69 pp	0.419
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3) = 5.15$ $p = 0.161$
Workers	47.50	52.60	+5.10 pp	
Students	5.50	10.30	+4.80 pp	
Unemployed	9.00	6.20	-2.80 pp	
Retired	38.00	30.90	-7.10 pp	

Table 4. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (France)

Table 5 and 6 report balance tests for neighboring countries and rest of Europe samples, respectively. In the neighboring countries sample, treatment and control groups appear well balanced across all

observed covariates: none of the differences reach conventional statistical significance, consistent with the pattern already observed for France.

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	50.80 (18.6)	50.60 (18)	+0.20	0.757
Female, %	53.52	53.74	-0.22 pp	0.912
Rural, %	35.11	37.38	-2.27 pp	0.237
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3) = 2.82$ $p = 0.421$
Workers	52.50	53.80	+1.30 pp	
Students	7.90	7.70	-0.20 pp	
Unemployed	8.80	10.20	+1.40 pp	
Retired	30.70	28.30	+2.40 pp	

Table 5. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (Neighboring Countries)

The picture is different for the rest of Europe sample. While age and gender remain balanced, both area of residence and current occupation show statistically significant imbalances between the treatment and control groups, with the occupation distribution in particular differing sharply. According to Muñoz et al. (2020), given the considerably larger sample size in this group compared to France and neighboring countries, these imbalances should be interpreted with some caution: a larger sample increases statistical power to detect even small differences, meaning that some of the observed imbalances may reflect substantively minor rather than substantively meaningful differences. Nonetheless, the consistency and joint significance of these imbalances suggest that they are unlikely to be attributable to sampling variation alone.

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	49.31 (18.2)	48.90 (17.8)	+0.41	0.144
Female, %	53.38	53.81	-0.43 pp	0.568
Rural, %	30.82	29.15	+1.67 pp	0.021
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3)= 22.96$ $p < 0.001$
Workers	53.20	56.70	+3.50 pp	
Students	7.00	6.70	-0.30 pp	
Unemployed	10.20	8.80	-1.40 pp	
Retired	29.50	27.80	-1.70 pp	

Table 6. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (Rest of Europe)

A broadly similar pattern emerged for the PEC sample (Table 7). Gender remains balanced between the treatment and control groups, while age, area of residence, and current occupation all show statistically significant imbalances. As with the rest of Europe sample, the relatively large sample size likely contributes to the statistical significance of some of these differences, even where the underlying magnitude is limited (Muñoz et al. 2020).

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	52.03 (18.1)	50.41(17.7)	1.62	0.006
Female, %	52.00	51.70	-0.30 pp	0.898
Rural, %	34.87	26.60	-8.27 pp	< 0.001
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3)=14.96$ p = 0.002
Workers	49.30	55.20	+5.90 pp	
Students	7.30	7.10	-0.20 pp	
Unemployed	9.30	8.90	-0.40 pp	
Retired	34.10	28.80	-5.30 pp	

Table 7. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (Previous Exposure Countries)

Considering this evidence, covariate adjustment is needed for the rest of Europe sample and for PEC sample, in order to satisfy the more plausible *Conditional Ignorability Assumptio*n before estimating the treatment effect. Following the empirical strategy outlined in Section 3.3, entropy balancing (Hainmueller, 2012) is applied to reweight the control group so that its covariate distribution matches that of the treatment group on the imbalanced pretreatment characteristics. Because entropy balancing is restricted to pretreatment covariates only, this adjustment does not condition on any variable potentially affected by the attacks themselves, thereby avoiding post-treatment bias.

3.3.2 Entropy Balancing

Following Muñoz et al. (2020), this imbalance is addressed using entropy balancing, a reweighting method introduced by Hainmueller (2012) for observational studies with a binary treatment. The method directly incorporates covariate balance into the construction of the weights: rather than first estimating a propensity score and subsequently checking whether the resulting weights achieve adequate balance, entropy balancing directly imposes a set of prespecified balance constraints on the covariate distributions. It then finds a set of weights for the control units such that the specified moments of the reweighted control group match those of the treatment group.

The intuition is to make the treatment and control groups more comparable with respect to their observed characteristics before estimating the treatment effect. This is particularly relevant in our setting because, although treatment assignment is determined by the timing of the interview, the composition of respondents may differ across the pre- and post-event periods by chance. If such differences are not accounted for, part of the observed difference in terrorism salience between the two groups could reflect differences in the composition of the respondents rather than the effect of the attacks themselves. Entropy balancing addresses this issue by reweighting the control observations so that the resulting control group has the same distribution of the prespecified covariates as the treatment group (Muñoz et al., 2020).

In the present analysis, entropy balancing is applied to the ROE and PEC sample, since they both present significant covariate imbalances. All four pretreatment covariates used throughout the analysis are included as balancing constraints, rather than only rural residence and occupation, which were the two variables found to be significantly imbalanced. This choice ensures consistency with the set of covariates used in the empirical strategy and avoids selectively balancing only those covariates identified as imbalanced in the preliminary tests. Moreover, it is consistent with the approach adopted by Muñoz et al. (2020) in their own empirical application, where entropy balancing is applied to all covariates included in the estimation of treatment effects, rather than only those found to be imbalanced in preliminary tests.

Implementation. The sample is first restricted to observations with non-missing values on the covariates included in the balancing procedure and in the subsequent outcome model. The treatment indicator is defined as a binary variable, equal to one for respondents interviewed after the attacks and zero for those interviewed before.

Because the entropy balancing algorithm requires the covariates to be provided as a numerical matrix (Hainmueller, 2012), the categorical covariate current occupation is decomposed into a set of 0/1 dummy variables, with *Workers* as the reference category and *Students*, *Unemployed*, and *Retired* included as separate indicators; this avoids perfect multicollinearity and ensures the covariate matrix has full column rank. When estimating the main outcome model, by contrast, current occupation is included in its original four-category form. The algorithm takes the treatment indicator and the covariate matrix for the control group and determines a set of weights such that the reweighted control group matches the treatment group on the specified covariate moments, while keeping the weights as close as possible to their original base values. As discussed previously, all four pretreatment covariates are included in the balancing procedure.

Balance constraints are imposed only on the first moment (the mean) of each covariate. This choice is consistent with the balance tests presented in Section 3.3.1, which assess covariate imbalance in terms of differences in means and category proportions; balancing the first moment therefore directly addresses the type of imbalance identified in that analysis. For the binary covariates (gender, rural residence, and the occupation indicators), exact balance in the mean automatically implies exact balance in the variance, since the variance of a binary variable is a direct function of its mean. For age, the only continuous covariate, matching the mean does not guarantee variance balance; this is not considered a substantive concern here, since the preliminary imbalance detected for age was limited to the mean.

Results. The entropy balancing procedure converges successfully, with a maximum moment deviation of 7.52×10^{-5}: the largest residual difference in covariate means between the treatment and reweighted control groups after optimization, negligibly close to the theoretical target of exact balance. This indicates that the algorithm found a set of weights satisfying the specified balance constraints with only negligible numerical deviation.

Table 8 reports covariate balance before and after entropy balancing for the rest of Europe sample, using the standardized mean difference (SMD): the difference in covariate means between the treatment and control groups, divided by their pooled standard deviation; as a scale-free measure of imbalance. As shown in the table, the reweighting substantially improves comparability between the treatment and control groups: standardized differences drop to zero for all covariates included in the balancing constraints after reweighting. These results indicate that entropy balancing successfully eliminates the observed covariate imbalance on the moments included in the weighting procedure. This exact balance is achieved by construction, which is one of the main advantages of entropy balancing over approaches that first estimate treatment probabilities and subsequently assess whether the resulting weights achieve adequate balance (Hainmueller, 2012). The corresponding results for the PEC sample follow the same procedure and are reported in Appendix E (Table E1).

Variable	*Mean, Treatment*	*Mean, Control (pre)*	*Mean, Control (post)*	*Std.Diff (pre)*	*Std. Diff. (post)*
Age	48.897	49.327	48.897	-0.024	0.000
Female	0.538	0.534	0.538	0.009	0.000
Rural	0.292	0.308	0.292	-0.036	0.000
Occupation: Student	0.067	0.072	0.067	-0.014	0.000
Occupation: Unemployed	0.088	0.102	0.088	-0.050	0.000
Occupation: Retired	0.278	0.295	0.278	-0.038	0.000

Table 8. Covariate Balance Before and After Entropy Balancing

The distribution of the resulting weights is also examined to assess whether the balancing procedure requires substantial reweighting of individual control observations (Figure 5). The 9,346 control units receive weights ranging from 0.6063 to 0.8783, with a mean of 0.7794 and a median of 0.7774. While the distribution displays a mild bimodal pattern, likely reflecting the discrete combinations of the underlying pretreatment covariates, all weights remain within a narrow range with no extreme values. This indicates that the reweighting is reasonably homogeneous across control observations, with no small subset of control units receiving disproportionately large weights.

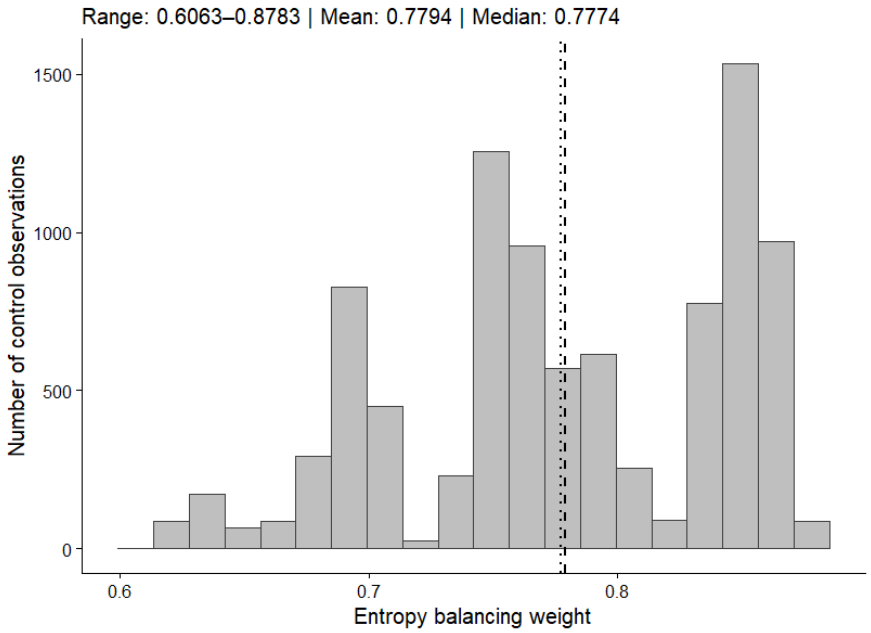


Figure 5. Distribution of Entropy Balancing Weights

In addition, the coefficient of variation of the weights, defined as the standard deviation divided by the mean, is approximately 0.08, indicating limited dispersion around the mean. This confirms that the entropy-balancing procedure did not require substantial departures from the underlying uniform weighting scheme to achieve the desired covariate balance, consistent with the entropy balancing objective of satisfying the balance constraints while keeping the resulting weights as close as possible to the base weights, thereby preserving information from the original sample (Hainmueller, 2012).

The same procedure is applied for the PEC sample. As shown in Appendix E, entropy balancing reduces the standardized differences to zero for all covariates included in the balancing constraints, indicating successful balance across the treatment and control groups (Table E1). The maximum residual deviation from the balancing constraints is only 0.00837. The resulting weights range from 0.3301 to 0.7386, with a mean of 0.5441 and a median of 0.5254 (Figure E1). The absence of extreme weights suggests that the entropy-balancing procedure does not rely on disproportionately large weights.

The resulting weights are used to construct the empirical models for the rest of Europe and Previous Exposure Countries samples, as detailed in Section 4.1.2. For the France and neighboring countries samples, which already satisfy the balance criteria without reweighting, the outcome models are instead estimated on the original, unweighted observations.

3.4 Noncompliance

The UESD assumes *full compliance*: respondents assigned to the treatment are assumed to have actually been exposed to the event, rather than merely having the opportunity to be exposed. However, some respondents interviewed after the event may not have received information about it. This gives rise to the possibility of one-sided noncompliance, whereby some individuals assigned to the treatment group are never-takers, meaning that they were not actually exposed to the event despite being assigned to the treatment group. Under these circumstances, the difference in outcomes between respondents interviewed before and after the event cannot be directly interpreted as the average treatment effect (ATE) of actual exposure.

Given the exceptional media salience of 13 November Paris attacks across Europe, one-sided noncompliance is unlikely to be a major concern, especially for French and neighboring countries. However, this may not be the case of the ROE sample, where exposure to information about the attacks may have been comparatively less immediate for respondents. To address this issue, the

approach adopted by Nussio et al. (2021) in their comparative study is followed. They test for a diffusion effect by interacting the treatment variable with a contiguity dummy, coded 1 if a respondent's country shares a direct border with the targeted country and 0 otherwise. They find that the effect of the attacks on attention to terrorism is stronger and more consistent in neighboring countries than in non-neighboring ones, interpreting this pattern as evidence that geographic proximity increases the likelihood of exposure to news about the attacks at the time of the interview.

This logic is adapted to the present study by estimating the treatment effect separately across four samples: France, neighboring countries, the Rest of Europe, and countries with previous exposure to terrorism. The first three samples allow for an assessment of how the estimated effect varies with geographical proximity to the targeted country, while the fourth captures the role of prior national experience with terrorism as a dimension of experiential proximity. If geographical proximity is related to the timeliness and intensity of exposure, the estimated treatment effect is expected to be strongest in France, somewhat smaller but still detectable in neighboring countries, and weaker in the rest of Europe. Similarly, comparing the results for countries with and without previous exposure to terrorism provides insights into the role of prior experience in shaping responses to the attacks. Differences across samples are assessed by comparing the estimates obtained from the separate models, rather than through a formal statistical test of differences between treatment effects.

Some limitations of this strategy should nonetheless be acknowledged. Comparing the treatment effect estimates across the different samples cannot establish the presence of one-sided noncompliance, since individual-level exposure to news about the attacks is not directly observed. The coefficient estimated for the Rest of Europe should therefore be interpreted as an intention-to-treat (ITT) effect, reflecting assignment to the post-event group rather than confirmed exposure to the event. Under one-sided noncompliance, this estimate may understate the effect of actual exposure. A smaller and less precise estimate in this sample is therefore consistent with, but does not definitively confirm, the presence of noncompliance, as it may also reflect genuine differences in responses across populations.

3.5 Heterogeneous Treatment Effects and Posttreatment Bias

A central feature of the analysis is the comparison of the treatment effect across the four samples. This comparison can be considered as a form of heterogeneous effects, as it examines whether the effect of the Paris attacks on terrorism salience varies according to geographical proximity and prior national experience with terrorism.

When studying heterogeneous effects, however, particular attention must be paid to the variables used to define the different groups. As Muñoz et al. (2020) note, conditioning a cross-sectional UESD estimates on variables that could themselves have been affected by the event can lead to posttreatment bias (Montgomery, Nyhan, and Torres 2018). This problem occurs when the variable used to define the groups changes as a result of the treatment. In this case, the comparison between the groups may no longer correctly identify the effect of the event, because the variable used for the comparison is itself influenced by the event (e.g. party identification, perceived threat).

In the present analysis this concern is limited because the groups are defined according to the respondent's country and its characteristics prior to the Paris attacks. Geographical proximity is determined by national borders, while previous exposure to terrorism is based on terrorist attacks that occurred before November 13, 2015. Neither classification can be affected by the Paris attacks themselves. However, differences in the estimated effects should be interpreted cautiously, as they may also reflect other differences across countries.

4. Empirical Strategy, Results and Robustness

4.1 Empirical Strategy

4.1.1 Model Specification

The relationship between the binary outcome variable and the explanatory variables is inherently nonlinear, since the predicted probability of the outcome must lie between 0 and 1. A linear probability model (estimated by OLS) does not guarantee this property and is also subject to heteroskedasticity by construction (Gujarati & Porter, 2009). For this reason, a Logit model is estimated as the baseline specification.

The Logit model. Let Y_i denote the outcome binary variable *Terrorism Salience* equal to 1 if respondent *I* identifies terrorism as one of the two most important issues facing their country, and 0 otherwise. The Logit model specified the conditional probability of the outcome as a logistic function of a linear index:

$$P(Y_i = 1|Treatment_i \boldsymbol{X}_i) = \Lambda(\beta_0 + \beta_1 Treatment_i + \boldsymbol{X'}_i\gamma) = \frac{\exp(\beta_0+\beta_1 Treatment_i+\boldsymbol{X\prime}_i\gamma)}{1+\exp(\beta_0+\beta_1 Treatment_i+\boldsymbol{X\prime}_i\gamma)} \quad (2)$$

where $\Lambda(\cdot)$ denotes the logistic cumulative distribution function, $Treatment_i$ is a binary indicator equal to 1 for respondents interviewed after the Paris attacks and 0 otherwise, and $\boldsymbol{X}_i$ is a vector of socio-demographic. The coefficient β_1 is the object of primary interest, capturing the effect of exposure to the attacks on the log-odds of citing terrorism as a salient issue:

$$\ln\left(\frac{P(Y_i=1)}{1-P(Y_i=1)}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Treatment_i + \boldsymbol{X'}_i\gamma \quad (3)$$

Odds Ratios. Because β_1 is expressed on the log-odds scale, it is not directly interpretable as a change in probability. The odds ratio associated with the treatment indicator is therefore additionally reported, obtained by exponentiating the corresponding coefficient:

$$OR_{Treatment} = \exp(\beta_1) \quad (4)$$

The odds ratio describes the multiplicative change in the odds of identifying terrorism as a salient issue following exposure to the attacks, holding the covariates in $\boldsymbol{X}_i$ constant. An odds ratio greater than 1 indicates that the odds of citing terrorism increase after the attacks, while a value below 1 indicates a decrease.

Average Marginal Effects. Because both the coefficients and the odds ratios are defined on a nonlinear scale, their magnitude is not directly comparable to a change in probability. Average Marginal Effects (AMEs) address this by expressing the estimated effect directly in terms of predicted probability. For the binary treatment variable, the AME is defined as the sample average of the discrete change in predicted probability associated with moving from $Treatment_i = 0$ to $Treatment_i = 1$, holding $\boldsymbol{X}_i$ at its observed values for each respondent:

$$AME_{Treatment} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}[\,\Lambda(\beta_0 + \beta_1 + \boldsymbol{X'}_i\gamma) - \Lambda(\beta_0 + \boldsymbol{X'}_i\gamma)] \quad (5)$$

Unlike the Logit coefficients and Odds Ratio, AMEs are expressed in percentage-point terms, providing the most directly interpretable measure of the substantive magnitude of the treatment effect, and are therefore the primary quantity used to interpret the results in Section 4.2.

4.1.2 Estimation Approach by Sample

For each geographical sample, models are estimated first without control variables and then including the full set of socio-demographic controls, in order to assess the sensitivity of the treatment effect estimated to the inclusion of covariates. The estimation procedure otherwise differs slightly across the four samples, reflecting the covariate balance results discussed in Chapter 3. For France and the neighboring countries, where the balance tests in Section 3.3.1 provide no evidence of systematic imbalance between the treatment and control groups, the Logit model in Equation (2) is estimated directly on the unweighted sample.

For the ROE and PEC sample, the imbalances identified in Section 3.3.1 are addressed through entropy balancing (Hainmueller, 2012), as described in Section 3.3.2. The resulting weights are assigned to the full sample: treated units retain their original weight of one, while control units are assigned the entropy-balancing weight obtained from the reweighting procedure; and Equation (2) is re-estimated on the weighted sample.

Because the entropy-balancing weights are continuous rather than integer-valued, estimating a standard binomial Logit produces a non-integer successes warning: the binomial family assumes that the product of weights and outcomes represents a count of successes out of a number of trials, an assumption that does not hold for calibration weights such as these. Following standard econometric practice for weighted binary outcome models, a quasibinomial specification is adopted instead, which yields identical maximum-likelihood point estimates to the binomial Logit but corrects the estimation of the dispersion parameter, thereby producing more reliable standard errors (McCullagh & Nelder,

1989)[7]. As the preferred specification, the weighted Logit model is estimated within a survey design framework (implemented via the survey package in R; Lumley, 2004), treating the entropy-balancing weights as calibration weights and allowing the standard errors to account for the fact that these weights are estimated rather than fixed.

4.2 Results: Attacks Effects on Terrorism Salience

Table 9 reports the estimated Logit coefficients for the treatment indicator and, where applicable, the socio-demographic controls. The treatment coefficient captures the difference in the log-odds of reporting terrorism as one of the two most important issues between respondents interviewed after and before the attacks.

The results show a positive and statistically significant treatment effect in all four geographical samples. In France, the coefficient increases from 1.745 in the specification without controls to 1.920 after their inclusion. This indicates that the estimated association between the attacks and terrorism salience remains positive and statistically significant after accounting for the observed socio-demographic characteristics. A positive and statistically significant treatment effect is also observed for neighboring countries, where the coefficient is 0.642 in both specifications. The stability of the coefficient after the inclusion of controls suggests that the estimated effect is not substantially affected by the observed socio-demographic characteristics included in the model. For the ROE, the treatment coefficient is 0.749 without controls and 0.750 with controls, and for the PEC sample it is 1.010 without control and 1.012 with controls. In both cases the similarity between the two estimates indicates that the inclusion of controls has little effect on the estimated treatment effect coefficient. Overall, when expressed in log-odds terms, the treatment coefficient is largest in France, followed by PEC sample, the ROE, and finally the neighboring countries.

[7] The quasibinomial family estimates the same coefficients as the standard binomial Logit but allows the dispersion parameter, fixed at 1 under the binomial assumption, to be estimated from the data. This relaxes the assumption that the variance of the outcome is fully determined by its mean, which is particularly relevant when observations are weighted, since fractional weights invalidate the binomial model's implicit assumption that weights represent integer counts of trials.

Variables	*France*	*France (with controls)*	*Neighbors*	*Neighbors (with controls)*	*ROE*	*ROE (with controls)*	*PEC*	*PEC (with controls)*
Treatment	1.745*** (0.244)	1.920*** (0.260)	0.642*** (0.136)	0.642*** (0.136)	0.749*** (0.059)	0.750*** (0.059)	1.010*** (0.104)	1.012*** (0.108)
Age		0.000 (0.010)		-0.003 (0.006)		-0.010*** (0.003)		0.006 (0.004)
Female		0.250 (0.296)		0.026 (0.137)		-0.071*** (0.059)		0.168 (0.112)
Rural		0.008 (0.296)		0.082 (0.141)		0.017 (0.064)		0.093 (0.123)
Student		-0.619 (0.602)		-0.219 (0.315)		-0.198 (0.126)		0.011 (0.264)
Unemployed		-0.873 (0.582)		0.028 (0.241)		-0.682*** (0.125)		-0.247 (0.216)
Retired		0.783* (0.383)		0.170 (0.210)		-0.065 (0.099)		-0.131 (0.171)
Constant	-1.665*** (0.133)	-2.083*** (0.508)	-2.653*** (0.091)	-2.581*** (0.298)	-2.832*** (0.046)	-2.216*** (0.136)	-2.689*** (0.080)	-3.071*** (0.251)
Observations	518	516	2,898	2,897	16,500	16,500	4,064	4,064
AIC	505.58	496.34	1633	1643.3	-	-	-	-

*Notes: The dependent variable is a binary indicator equal to 1 if terrorism is mentioned among the two most important issues and 0 otherwise. Treatment equals 1 for respondents interviewed after the attacks and 0 for those interviewed before the attacks. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. France and neighboring-country models are estimated on the unweighted sample, while rest-of-Europe models use entropy-balancing weights. For the rest of Europe (ROE) sample and Previous Exposure Countries (PEC), the weighted Logit is estimated within a survey design framework, treating the entropy-balancing weights as calibration weights. All models in the columns labelled "with controls" include age, female, rural residence, and occupation controls. *, **, and *** denote statistical significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels, respectively.*

Table 9: Logit Estimates of the Effect of the Paris Terrorist Attacks on Terrorism Salience

Because Logit coefficients are expressed in log-odds, their magnitude is not directly interpretable in probability terms. Table 10 therefore reports the corresponding odds ratios and 95% confidence intervals. In France, the odds ratio is 5.727 in the specification without controls and 6.820 when controls are included. Thus, the estimated odds of reporting terrorism among the two most important issues are considerably higher for respondents interviewed after the attacks than for those interviewed before them. The corresponding odds ratios are lower in the other two samples. For neighboring countries, the odds ratio is approximately 1.90 in both specifications, while for the rest of Europe it is approximately 2.12. For the PEC sample, the odds ratio is somewhat higher, at approximately 2.75 in both specifications, indicating that in countries with previous exposure to terrorism the post-attack increase in the odds of reporting terrorism as a key issue is more pronounced than in neighboring countries or in the rest of Europe, though still well below the increase observed in France.

Although odds ratios facilitate the comparison of the treatment effect across specifications, they do not express the effect directly in terms of changes in predicted probabilities. To provide an interpretation in probability terms, Table 11 reports the average marginal effects associated with the treatment indicator. In France, the treatment is associated with an increase of approximately 36.1 percentage points in the predicted probability of reporting terrorism among the two most important issues in the specification without controls. When controls are included, the estimated effect increases slightly to 37.6 percentage points. The estimated effects are considerably smaller outside France. In neighboring countries, the treatment is associated with an increase of approximately 5.2 percentage points in the predicted probability, both without and with controls. In the rest of Europe, the estimated increase is approximately 5.5 percentage points in both specifications, while in the PEC sample it is somewhat larger, at approximately 9.4 percentage points in both specifications.

Variables	*France*	*France (with controls)*	*Neighbors*	*Neighbors (with controls)*	*ROE*	*ROE (with controls)*	*PEC*	*PEC (with controls)*
Treatment	5.727***	6.820***	1.900***	1.901***	2.115***	2.117***	2.746***	2.752****
95% CI	[3.56, 9.27]	[4.12, 11.44]	[1.45, 2.48]	[1.45, 2,48]	[1.88, 2.37]	[1.88, 2.37]	[2.22, 3.40]	[2.22, 3.40]

*Notes: The table reports exponentiated coefficients from the Logit models, expressed as odds ratios. The 95% confidence intervals are reported in brackets. Treatment equals 1 for respondents interviewed after the attacks and 0 for respondents interviewed before the attacks. Models for France and neighboring countries are estimated on the unweighted sample, while rest-of-Europe and PEC models use entropy-balancing weights within a survey design framework. *, **, and *** denote statistical significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels, respectively.*

Table 10. Odds Ratios from Logit Models

Variables	*France*	*France (with controls)*	*Neighbors*	*Neighbors (with controls)*	*ROE*	*ROE (with controls)*	*PEC*	*PEC (with controls)*
Treatment	0.361*** (0.054)	0.376*** (0.052)	0.052*** (0.012)	0.052*** (0.012)	0.055*** (0.004)	0.055*** (0.004)	0.094*** (0.011)	0.094*** (0.011)

*Notes: The table reports average marginal effects from the corresponding Logit models. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. The marginal effects represent the change in the predicted probability of reporting terrorism among the two most important issues associated with the treatment indicator. Models for France and neighboring countries are estimated on the unweighted sample, while rest-of-Europe and PEC models use entropy-balancing weights within a survey design framework. *, **, and *** denote statistical significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels, respectively.*

Table 11. Average Marginal Effects from Logit Models

Taken together, the three tables show a consistent pattern across the different model specifications. The treatment effect is positive and statistically significant in all four geographical samples, while its magnitude differs substantially across them. The largest estimated effect is observed in France, where the attacks are associated with an increase of around 36-38 percentage points in the predicted probability of reporting terrorism as one of the two most important issues. The PEC sample displays the second-largest effect, at around 9 percentage points, suggesting that prior exposure to terrorism may amplify the salience response to a new attack relative to countries without such exposure. The estimated effects are considerably smaller in neighboring countries and in the rest of Europe, at around 5 percentage points. Moreover, the inclusion of socio-demographic controls produces only limited changes in the treatment estimates across all four samples.

4.3 Robustness Checks

4.3.1 Robustness to Alternative Bandwidths

To assess the robustness of the identification strategy to the choice of bandwidth, the models are re-estimated using an alternative time window, following the approach adopted by Muñoz et al. (2020) and Nussio et al. (2021). In addition to the main ±3-day specification, a narrower ±1-day window around the event is considered. This provides a more stringent comparison between respondents interviewed immediately before and after the attacks, thereby reducing the possibility that other events or changes in the composition of the sample over a longer period may affect the estimates. At the same time, however, it reduces the number of observations available for estimation and may therefore lead to less precise estimates. The resulting composition of the treatment and control groups under the ±1-day window, for each of the four samples, is reported in Appendix B.

Before re-estimating the outcome models, balance tests for pretreatment covariates are conducted using the ±1-day window, following the same procedure as in the main analysis. The results are reported in Appendix F.1. As in the main analysis, no significant imbalances are found for France or the neighboring countries sample, while the ROE and PEC samples present significant imbalances in current occupation and area of residence, respectively. For these two samples, entropy balancing is applied under the ±1-day bandwidth; the corresponding diagnostics are also reported in Appendix F.2. The full treatment effect estimates, including the logistic regression coefficients, odds ratios and average marginal effects, with and without controls, are reported in Appendix F.3.

The direction of the treatment effect is consistent across all four samples under the narrower bandwidth, providing support for the robustness of the main results. The estimated effect in France remains stable and slightly larger than in the main specification, while the estimates for the Neighboring Countries, ROE, and PEC are somewhat attenuated relative to the ±3-day specification, with the most pronounced reduction observed for the PEC sample.

A plausible explanation for the attenuated effects observed outside France is that the diffusion of terrorism-related news, and its translation into heightened issue salience, may require more than a single day to fully manifest among publics not directly exposed to the attack. This interpretation is consistent with the classic agenda-setting literature, which emphasizes that the choice of time-lag is critical for capturing causal media effects: a time-lag that is too short risks failing to capture the causal relationship, while a time-lag that is too long, risks allowing the effect to dissipate before it is measured (Wanta & Hu, 1994). While terrorist attacks are high-intensity events likely to generate faster public response, a single-day window may still be insufficient to fully capture the diffusion of the event's salience beyond the directly targeted country. This is consistent with the substantially larger and more stable effect observed in France, where the attacks were immediately and directly salient to respondents.

Overall, the ±1-day robustness check supports the main finding that the Paris attacks increased terrorism salience across all four samples, while also suggesting that the magnitude of this effect outside France, and particularly in previously exposed countries, may take slightly longer than a single day to fully emerge.

5. Discussion

5.1 The French Case: A Confirmatory and Contextuality Amplified Effect

The results obtained for France are consistent with the increase in terrorism attention documented by Nussio et al. (2021) following the same attacks, as well as with the substantial salience shifts reported by de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone (2021) following major terrorist attacks in France. These findings reinforce the relevance of the French context discussed in Section 1.2: France's previous experience with terrorism and the prominence of terrorism in the French public debate provide important context for understanding the strong response observed in this study. Moreover, since France was the country directly targeted by the attacks, a particularly strong response in terms of both perceptions and the political salience of terrorism would be expected relative to the other samples.

This raises the question of why the estimated effect in France is so pronounced. The magnitude of the increase in terrorism salience may be related to two connected features of the political and social context surrounding the attacks. First, the November attacks did not introduce terrorism into public consciousness for the first time. The Charlie Hebdo attack in January 2015 had already generated substantial public attention to terrorism and security earlier that year (de Roy van Zuijdewijn & Sciarone, 2021). A pre-existing level of concern about terrorism was therefore already present among French citizens by November 2015. Rather than creating an entirely new worry, the November attacks plausibly reactivated and reinforced an issue that had already been salient in French public opinion. Second, the attacks could be assimilated into a pre-existing interpretative framework linking terrorism, national security and questions of immigration and integration in France (Benhadda, 2025). Consistent with framing theory (Entman, 1993), an event that fits within an already established interpretative frame is more likely to register as salient than one requiring the construction of an entirely new frame of understanding. In the French case, the November 2015 attacks could therefore draw on a security-related narrative that had already developed over previous decades and, more immediately, over the preceding months.

Consistent with the logic of terrorism as a potential "killer issue" (Brosius & Kepplinger, 1995), these conditions plausibility facilitated an unusually rapid and pronounced reallocation of public attention toward terrorism in France, amplifying the effect relative to what a simple direct-exposure mechanism alone would predict. The attacks occurred only three weeks before the first round of the 2015 regional

elections[8], and the subsequent electoral campaign was strongly shaped by their aftermath, including the declaration of state of emergency and the heightened prominence of security and counter-terrorism issues[9]. This broader political response is consistent with the agenda setting potential of the attacks (Zhu, 1992): the increase in terrorism salience observed in the survey was accompanied by a wider shift in public and political attention towards terrorism and security.

5.2 Two Dimensions of Proximity

This section turns to the central question of the thesis: does proximity to a terrorist attack condition its effect on terrorism issue salience, and if so, what form of proximity matters? Two distinct dimensions are considered in turn: geographical proximity and experiential proximity.

The comparison between the neighboring countries and rest of Europe samples, provides the most direct test of the geographical proximity hypothesis advanced by Böhmelt et al. (2020). If proximity to the attacks systematically conditioned the intensity of the response the neighboring countries should have exhibited a substantially larger increase in terrorism salience than the rest of Europe.

The findings do not support this expectation. The absence of a clear difference between the two samples suggests that geographical proximity did not amplify the immediate salience response to the Paris attacks. This contrasts with Böhmelt et al. (2020), who show that the effects of terrorist attacks on migration concern can diffuse across national borders, highlighting the role of geographical proximity in the transmission of terrorism-related attitudes. It is, however, consistent with (Nussio et al., 2019), who examine the November 2015 Paris attacks and find no evidence that geographical proximity amplified its effect on migration attitudes. They find stronger effects in countries with lower levels of prior immigration, pointing instead to the local migration context as an important conditioning factor.

Taken together, these findings suggest that the relevance of geographical proximity may depend on both the outcome and the context under study, rather than representing a general mechanism through

[8] Ministère de l'Intérieur, "Dossier de presse des élections régionales 2015", https://www.interieur.gouv.fr/fr/Archives/Archives-elections/Elections-regionales-2015/Dossier-de-presse-des-elections-regionales-2015 (Last access: 26 September 2026)
[9] Jérôme Fourquet and Sylvain Manternach, "Régionales 2015 (1) : vote FN et attentats", https://www.fondapol.org/etude/jerome-fourquet-et-sylvain-manternach-regionales-2015-1-vote-fn-et-attentats (Last access: 26 September 2026)

which the effects of terrorist attacks spread across borders. In the case of terrorism salience, proximity alone does not appear to systematically shape the immediate public response.

On the other hand, the results provide clear evidence that prior national exposure to terrorism conditions the intensity of the response to a new attack. This is consistent with the theoretical expectation that experiential proximity may operate as a distinct mechanism from geographical proximity in shaping the salience of terrorism as an issue.

Three complementary explanations help account for this pattern. First, following Criado (2017), citizens in countries that have previously experienced domestic terrorism may possess a more developed interpretative framework through which to process a new, geographically distant attack, making it more readily identifiable as personally and nationally relevant. Second, consistent with framing theory (Entman, 1993) and the logic of terrorism as a "killer issue" (Brosius & Kepplinger, 1995) a new attack occurring elsewhere may more easily activate an existing rooted terrorism frame in previously exposed countries, in a manner broadly analogous to what occurred in France, as discussed in Section 5.1. Third, prior exposure to a domestic attack may prime a form of recall or association with that earlier event, a possibility broadly consistent with evidence that new terrorist attacks trigger renewed public attention to past, similar attacks.

This third explanation finds more direct support in psychological research on repeated exposure to collective trauma. Garfin et al. (2015) examine acute stress responses to the 2013 Boston Marathon bombing among resident of Boston and New York, assessing their cumulative direct and indirect exposure to three prior collective traumas: the September 11, 2001, attacks, Hurricane Sandy, and the Sandy Hook Elementary School shooting. They find that greater cumulative prior exposure to these events, was associated with stronger acute stress responses to the subsequent Boston Marathon bombing, consistent with a sensitization mechanism whereby repeated exposure to collective trauma heightens, rather than blunts, the psychological response to a new, unrelated traumatic event. This provides psychological evidence for the plausibility of the mechanism proposed here: prior national exposure to terrorism may similarly sensitize citizens of previous exposure countries to a new attack occurring elsewhere.

This interpretation also finds support in recent research on the psychological mechanism underlying fear of terrorism following indirect exposure. Cohen-Louck et al. (2026) show that fear of terrorism among individuals indirectly exposed to a distant attack is predicted not by physical distance from the event, but by their perceived psychological distance from its direct victims: greater perceived closeness to the victims was associated with stronger fear responses, even though respondents were

not themselves physically present. Applied to the present findings, this suggests a plausible mechanism through which prior national exposure to terrorism may reduce the psychological distance between citizens of previously exposed countries and the victims of a new, geographically remote attack, thereby intensifying its salience.

Together, Garfin et al. (2015) and Cohen-Louck et al. (2026) point to the same underlying conclusion from two different angles, one based on cumulative trauma exposure, the other on perceived closeness to victims: what appears to matter for the intensity of the response to a new terrorist attack is not geographical distance, but whether the event is experienced as psychologically close. Prior national exposure to terrorism is well positioned to produce exactly this kind of closeness, even in the complete absence of geographical proximity to the new attack.

Considered jointly, these findings suggest a reframing of the proximity hypothesis as it applies to terrorism issue salience. Rather than treating geographical proximity and experiential as competing explanations, the results indicate that they may operate as distinct, outcome-specific mechanism. Being geographically close to an affected country may be more relevant for outcomes involving concrete, indirect attitudes, such as immigration concern, because geographical proximity can make perceived risk, cross-border population movements and the anticipated domestic consequences of an attack in a neighboring country more tangible (Böhmelt et al., 2020). Terrorism issue salience, however, appears to function differently. What may instead condition the intensity of the salience response is the presence of a terrorism frame rooted in prior national experience, activated through experiential rather than geographical proximity. In this sense, proximity at a more psychological level, rather than physical distance alone, may be more relevant for this outcome.

Conclusion

This thesis examines whether proximity conditions the intensity of the public response to a terrorist attack, and more specifically, whether proximity should be understood beyond geographical distance. Using the 13 November 2015 Paris attacks as an Unexpected Event during Survey Design (UESD), the analysis investigates changes in terrorism issue salience among respondents interviewed immediately before and after the attacks. The empirical strategy compares France with neighboring countries and the rest of Europe and subsequently considers a broader form of proximity based on previous national exposure to terrorism.

The thesis first reviews the literature on terrorism and public opinion, focusing on the capacity of terrorist attacks to affect political attitudes beyond their direct victims (Nussio et al., 2021). Previous research provides evidence that geographical proximity can condition responses to terrorist events in some contexts (Böhmelt et al., 2020), whereas other studies have found limited evidence of geographical diffusion in the effects of terrorist attacks on public attitudes (Nussio et al., 2019). The literature also points to the importance of previous exposure and contextual factors in shaping how individuals interpret subsequent terrorist events (Criado, 2017). Building on these perspectives, this thesis distinguished between geographical proximity and experiential proximity as two potentially different dimensions though which a terrorist attack may affect public attention.

The empirical analysis uses Eurobarometer 84.3, whose fieldwork took place between 7 and 17 November 2015, allowing for the use of a UESD around the 13 November attacks. The main analysis focuses on a ±3-day bandwidth and excludes respondents interviewed on the day of the attacks. Terrorism issue salience was measured using the respondent's selection of terrorism among the two most important issues facing the country. The analysis was conducted separately for France, neighboring countries, and the rest of Europe, and was extended to countries with previous national exposure to terrorism.

The results provide three main findings. First, the strongest response is observed in France, where terrorism salience increased substantially among respondents interviewed after the attack, consistent with the particularly prominent role of terrorism and security in the French context at the time (Brouard et al., 2018). Second, the analysis does not reveal a clear geographical gradient across Europe. Countries neighboring France do not display a systematically stronger increase in terrorism salience than the rest of Europe, suggesting that geographical proximity alone does not explain differences in the salience response and that the relevance of proximity may depend on the specific outcome through which the consequences of terrorism are observed. Third, a different pattern emerges

when proximity is defined through previous national exposure to terrorism. Countries with prior experience of terrorist attacks show a stronger response to the Paris attacks than countries without such experience. This result points to experiential proximity as a potentially relevant dimension of closeness, although the data do not allow the underlying mechanism to be identified.

Taken together, the findings contribute to the literature by qualifying rather than rejecting the proximity hypothesis. Geographical and experiential proximity should not necessarily be understood as competing explanations. Instead, they may represent different dimensions of proximity that become relevant depending on the outcome under consideration. For terrorism salience, the evidence presented here provides little support for a simple geographical gradient across European countries, while the stronger response observed in countries with previous national exposure is consistent with a role for contextual and experiential closeness. In this sense, the findings extend the discussion of proximity by suggesting that physical distance alone may provide an incomplete account of how terrorist attacks translate into changes in public attention.

Several limitations should nevertheless be considered. First, the analysis focuses on a single terrorist event. Although the Paris attacks provide a particularly useful setting for a UESD design, their exceptional severity and the specific French political context limit the generalizability of the findings. Second, previous exposure to terrorism is measured at the national level and does not capture individual differences in exposure, perceived threat, media consumption, or personal experiences. As a result, the analysis cannot establish the mechanisms underlying the stronger response observed in countries with previous experience of terrorism. Finally, the short UESD window is well suited to identifying immediate changes in issue salience but provides limited information about the persistence or longer-term evolution of these effects.

These limitations point to several directions for future research. First, replicating the analysis across multiple terrorist attacks and different national contexts would help assess whether the distinction between geographical and experiential proximity extends beyond the Paris case. Second, using individual-level measures of previous exposure, together with data on media consumption and perceived threat, could provide a more precise understanding of the factors underlying differences in the salience response. Finally, extending the observation window beyond the immediate aftermath of an attack would make it possible to examine whether these effects persist over time and how the role of geographical and experiential proximity may evolve.

Overall, this thesis suggests that the consequences of terrorism cannot be understood solely in terms of the physical distance between an attack and its audience. These findings support a more differentiated understanding of proximity in the study of terrorism and public opinion: rather than treating proximity as a single geographical concept, future research should consider how physical distance interacts with previous experience and the contextual frameworks through which terrorist events are interpreted.



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Appendix

A. Classification of Previous Exposure Countries and Reference Terrorist Attacks

This appendix provides additional detail on the classification of countries included in the Previous Exposure Countries (PEC) sample, as discussed in Chapter 2.4. Table A1 lists, for each country, the terrorist attack(s) considered for classification purposes, the date of occurrence, the type of attack, and a brief note on its relevance relative to the November 2015 Paris attacks. Countries were included in the PEC sample if they experienced at least one terrorist attack between January 2000 and 13 November 2015, regardless of the ideological motivation behind it.

Table A1. Terrorist Attacks Used for the Classification of Previous Exposure Countries

Country	***Attack(s) Considered***	***Date***	***Type***	***Relevance***
Spain	Madrid train bombings (11-M)	March 2004	Jihadist	191 deaths; the deadliest jihadist attack in Europe before Paris
United Kingdom	7/7 London bombings / Lee Rigby murder	July 2005 / May 2013	Jihadist	52 deaths (7/7); Rigby case more recent and widely covered
Germany	Frankfurt Airport shooting	March 2011	Jihadist	2 deaths; less severe but more recent
Belgium	Brussels Jewish Museum shooting	May 2014	Jihadist	Occurred close in time to Paris (18 months prior)
Bulgaria	Burgas bus bombing	July 2012	Shia/Hezbollah	Different jihadist matrix; still relevant as an act of international terrorism on Bulgarian soil
Denmark	Copenhagen shootings	February 2015	Jihadist	Only 9 months before Paris; highest temporal relevance
Netherlands	Murder of Theo van Gogh	November 2004	Jihadist (targeted killing)	Individual attack, not mass casualty

Notse: Classification based on Europol's EU Terrorism Situation and Trend Report (TE-SAT)[10], various years. Details on individual attacks were cross-checked against national security reports and major news outlets where necessary.

[10] Europol, "Main Reports", https://www.europol.europa.eu/publications-events/main-reports (Last access: 16 September 2026)

B. Fieldwork Distribution and Sample Composition

This appendix reports the distribution of Eurobarometer 84.3 interviews over the fieldwork period for each of the four geographical samples analyzed. Table B1 presents the daily number of interviews across the full available fieldwork period. Table B2 then reports the resulting composition of the control and treatment groups used in the main analysis, while Table B3 presents the composition of these groups under the ±1-day bandwidth used for the robustness checks discussed in Section 4.3.1.

Table B1. Daily Number of Interviews

Date	***France***	***Neighboring Countries***	***Rest of Europe***	***Previous Exposure Countries***
7 Nov	157	544	1,904	658
8 Nov	33	253	1,996	298
9 Nov	169	707	2,951	979
10 Nov	174	749	3,268	1,054
11 Nov	36	498	2,970	668
12 Nov	211	728	3,115	911
13 Nov – excluded	149	647	2,998	640
14 Nov	90	463	2,877	557
15 Nov	3	149	2,564	418
16 Nov	4	311	1,847	457
17 Nov	-	53	215	-

Table B2. Composition of Treatment and Control Groups (±3-Day Bandwidth)

Group	***France***	***Neighboring Countries***	***Rest of Europe***	***Previous Exposure Countries***
Control (before attack)	421	1,975	9,231	2,633
Treatment (after attack)	97	923	7,280	1,432

Notes: The treatment and control groups are defined based on the timing of the Eurobarometer interviews relative to November 13, 2015 Paris attacks. The analysis is restricted to ±3-day window around the attack, covering November 10–16, 2015, and excludes interviews conducted on the day of the attacks. Respondents interviewed before the attacks (November 10–12) are assigned to the control group, while those interviewed after the attacks (November 14–16) are assigned to the treatment group. Observations with missing values on the terrorism salience outcome are excluded.

Table B3. Composition of Treatment and Control Groups (±1-Day Bandwidth)

Group	***France***	***Neighboring Countries***	***Rest of Europe***	***Previous Exposure Countries***
Control (before attack)	211	728	3,077	911
Treatment (after attack)	90	463	2,869	557

Notes: The treatment and control groups are defined based on the timing of the Eurobarometer interviews relative to the Paris attacks on November 13, 2015. The analysis is restricted to a ±1-day window around the attack, covering November 12–14, 2015, and excludes interviews conducted on the day of the attacks. Respondents interviewed before the attacks (November 12) are assigned to the control group, while those interviewed after the attacks (November 14) are assigned to the treatment group. Observations with missing values on the terrorism salience outcome are excluded.

C. Descriptive Statistics of Control Variables

This appendix reports the descriptive statistics for the four socio-demographic control variables included in the analysis, as discussed in Section 2.5.3. Table C1 provides, for each variable, a brief description, its coding, and the corresponding sample statistics: the mean and standard deviation for the continuous variable (Age), and the frequency and percentage share for the three categorical/dummy variables (Female, Rural, Occupation). These statistics refer to the full Eurobarometer 84.3 sample, prior to the listwise deletion of observations with missing values applied in the main empirical analysis.

Table C1. Description and Descriptive Statistics of Control Variables

Variable	***Description***	***Coding***	***Mean (SD) / N (%)***
Age	Respondent's age	Continuous, years (range 15-99)	48.48 (18.21)
Female	Respondent's gender	1 = Female, 0 = Male	17.552 (53.50%)
Rural	Respondent's area of residence	1 = Rural, 0 = Urban / Town	9.903 (30.20%)
Occupation	Respondent's current occupation	Categorical: Retired / Student / Unemployed / Worker	Retired: 9,647 (29.40%) Student: 2,296 (7.00%) Unemployed: 3,050 (9.30%) Worker: 17,840 (54.30%)

Notes: descriptive statistics are based on the Eurobarometer 84.3 sample (N = 32,833) before applying listwise deletion for missing values

D. Robustness Checks for the Simultaneous Events Threat

This appendix reports supporting material for the assessment of the simultaneous events threat discussed in Section 3.2.3. Figures D1, D2 and D3 show the daily share of respondents mentioning terrorism and immigration as one of the two most important issues facing their country, for neighboring countries, the ROE and PEC samples. Table D1 reports the corresponding logistic regression estimates for the samples.

Figure D1. Daily Share of Respondents Mentioning Terrorism and Immigration (Neighboring Countries)

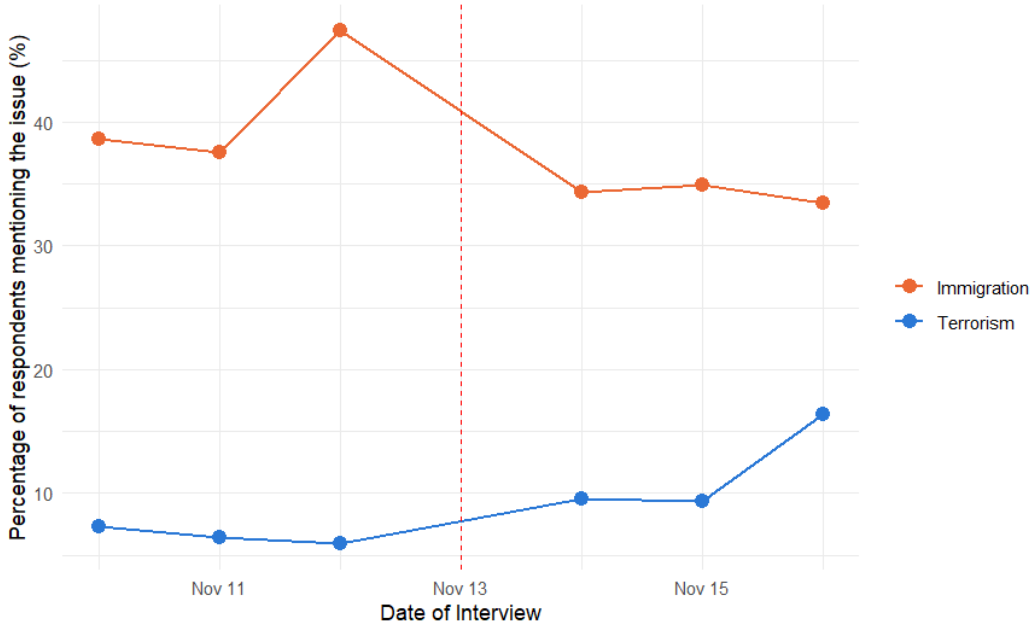


Figure D2. Daily Share of Respondents Mentioning Terrorism and Immigration (Rest of Europe)

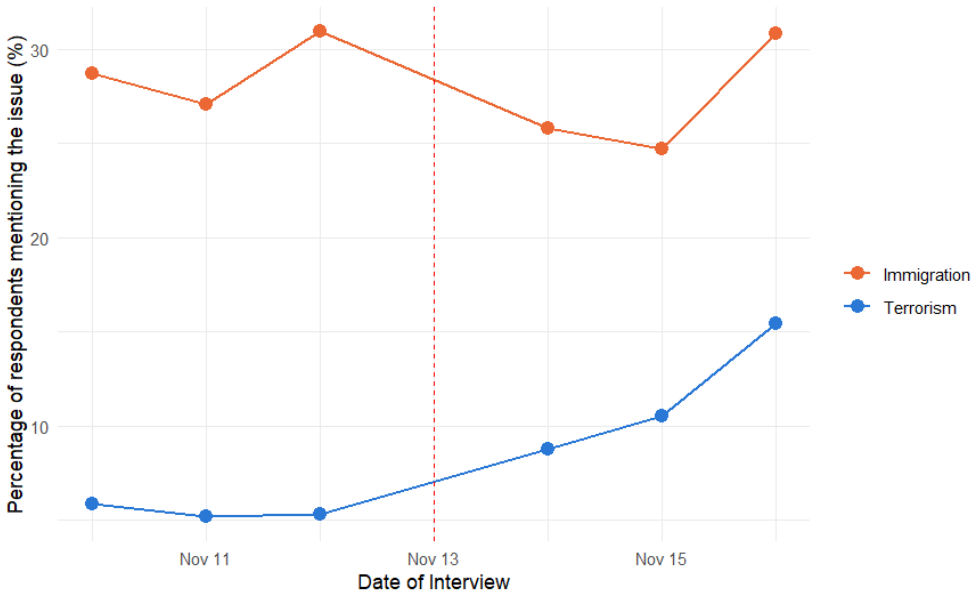


Figure D3. Daily Share of Respondents Mentioning Terrorism and Immigration (Previous Exposure Countries)

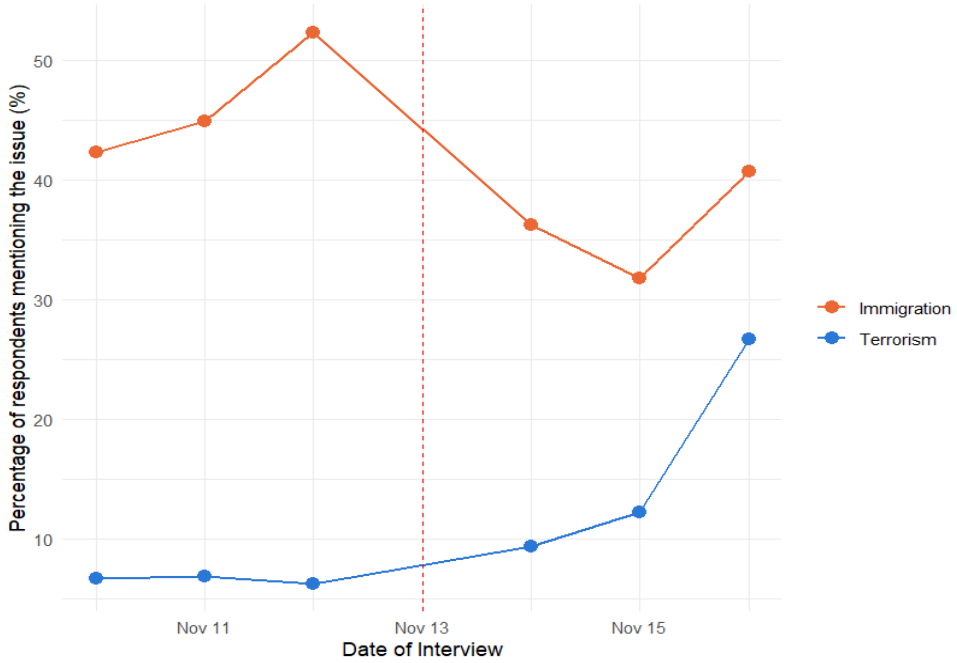


Table D1. Logistic Regression Estimates of the Effect of the Paris Attacks on Terrorism and Immigration Salience, by Sample

Sample	***Outcome***	***Treatment***	***SE***	***p-value***
France	Terrorism	1.726***	0.243	<0.001
France	Immigration	0.243	0.278	0.382
Neighboring countries	Terrorism	0.642***	0.136	<0.001
Neighboring countries	Immigration	-0.317***	0.083	<0.001
Rest of Europe	Terrorism	0.768***	0.059	<0.001
Rest of Europe	Immigration	-0.113***	0.035	<0.001
Previous Exposure Countries	Terrorism	0.975***	0.107	<0.001
Previous Exposure Countries	Immigration	-0.416***	0.067	<0.001

Notes: each coefficient reports the estimated effect of the post-attack treatment indicator from a separate logistic regression model. The dependent variable is a binary indicator equal to one if the respondent mentions terrorism or immigration, respectively, among the two most important issues facing their country. All models are estimated using the ±3-day bandwidth around November 13, 2015 (November 10–16), excluding interviews conducted on the day of the attacks

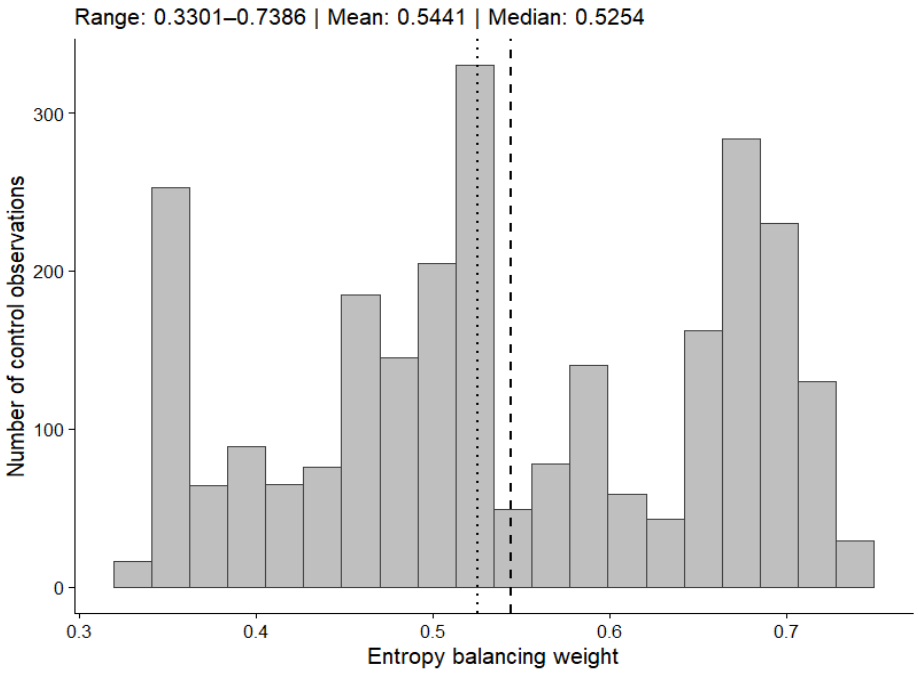
E. Entropy Balancing Results for Previous Exposure Countries

This appendix reports supporting material for entropy balancing procedure discussed in Section 3.3.2. Table E1 presents the covariate balance before and after entropy balancing, while Figure E1 shows the distribution of the resulting entropy balancing weights for the PEC sample.

Table E1. Covariate Balance Before and After Entropy Balancing

Variable	***Mean, Treatment***	***Mean, Control (pre)***	***Mean, Control (post)***	***Std.Diff (pre)***	***Std. Diff. (post)***
Age	50.414	52.032	50.414	-0.090	0.000
Female	0.517	0.519	0.517	-0.005	0.000
Rural	0.266	0.348	0.266	-0.180	0.000
Occupation: Student	0.070	0.072	0.070	-0.009	0.000
Occupation: Unemployed	0.089	0.093	0.089	-0.013	0.000
Occupation: Retired	0.287	0.341	0.287	-0.116	0.000

Figure E1. Distribution of Entropy Balancing Weights



F. Robustness Checks: Balance Tests for the ±1-Day Bandwidth

This appendix reports the robustness checks for the ±1-day bandwidth, presented in Section 4.3.1, organized in three parts: balance tests for the pretreatment covariates (F.1), entropy balancing diagnostics (F.2), and treatment effect estimates (F.3).

F.1 Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates

This section reports the balance tests for the pretreatment covariates under the ±1-day bandwidth. For each of the four samples, Tables F1–F4 report the mean values of age, gender, area of residence, and current occupation for the treatment and control groups, together with the corresponding difference.

Table F1. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (France, ±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	54.77 (20.1)	51.31 (19.3)	3.46	0.161
Female, %	47.86	50.00	-2.14	0.736
Rural, %	19.04	21.34	-2.30	0.655
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3) = 3.426$ $p = 0.330$
Workers	44.50	52.20	-7.70	
Students	5.70	8.90	-3.20	
Unemployed	9.50	6.70	2.80	
Retired	40.30	32.20	8.10	

Table F2. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (Neighboring Countries, ±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	51.28 (18.9)	50.23 (18.1)	1.05	0.333
Female, %	55.78	54.00	1.78	0.549
Rural, %	36.81	36.71	0.10	0.973
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3) = 2.209$ $p = 0.530$
Workers	50.50	53.10	-2.60	
Students	8.10	8.90	-0.80	
Unemployed	8.80	9.50	-0.70	
Retired	32.60	28.50	4.10	

Table F3. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (Rest of Europe, ±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	49.64 (18.4)	48.80 (17.9)	0.84	0.072
Female, %	54.15	54.22	-0.07	0.959
Rural, %	31.51	31.11	0.40	0.749
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3) = 12.11$ $p = 0.007$
Workers	51.40	55.60	-4.20	
Students	7.80	7.20	0.60	
Unemployed	10.60	8.90	1.70	
Retired	30.30	28.3	2.00	

Table F4. Balance Tests for Pretreatment Covariates (Previous Exposure Countries, ±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variable	***Control***	***Treatment***	***Difference***	***p-value***
Age, mean (SD)	52.86 (18.3)	51.12 (18.2)	1.74	0.076
Female, %	52.90	52.42	0.48	0.857
Rural, %	37.10	27.11	9.99	<0.001
Current occupation, %				$\chi^2(3) = 2.981$ p = 0.395
Workers	47.10	51.0	-3.90	
Students	7.60	8.10	-0.50	
Unemployed	8.80	8.60	0.20	
Retired	36.60	32.30	4.30	

F.2 Entropy Balancing Diagnostics

For the ROE and PEC samples, entropy balancing is applied to address the imbalances identified in Section F.1. Tables F5 and F6 report the resulting covariate balance and weight diagnostics after reweighting.

Table F5. Covariate Balance Before and After Entropy Balancing (Rest of Europe, ±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variable	***Mean, Treatment***	***Mean, Control (pre)***	***Mean, Control (post)***	***Std.Diff (pre)***	***Std. Diff. (post)***
Age	48.793	49.651	48.793	-0.047	0.000
Female	0.542	0.542	0.542	0.001	0.000
Rural	0.311	0.315	0.311	-0.008	0.000
Occupation: Student	0.072	0.078	0.072	-0.022	0.000
Occupation: Unemployed	0.088	0.106	0.088	-0.058	0.000
Occupation: Retired	0.283	0.303	0.283	-0.043	0.000

Table F6. Covariate Balance Before and After Entropy Balancing (Previous Exposure Countries, ±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variable	***Mean, Treatment***	***Mean, Control (pre)***	***Mean, Control (post)***	***Std.Diff (pre)***	***Std. Diff. (post)***
Age	51.122	52.862	51.122	-0.095	0.000
Female	0.524	0.529	0.524	-0.009	0.000
Rural	0.271	0.371	0.271	-0.215	0.000
Occupation: Student	0.081	0.075	0.081	0.0188	0.000
Occupation: Unemployed	0.086	0.088	0.086	-0.005	0.000
Occupation: Retired	0.323	0.366	0.323	-0.089	0.000

F.3 Treatment Effect Estimates

This section reports the treatment effect estimates under the ±1-day bandwidth, for each of the four samples, with and without socio-demographic controls. Table F7 reports the logistic regression coefficients, Table F8 the corresponding odds ratios, and Table F9 the average marginal effects (AME).

Table F7. Logit Estimates of the Effect of the Paris Terrorist Attacks on Terrorism Salience (±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variables	***France***	***France (with controls)***	***Neighbors***	***Neighbors (with controls)***	***ROE***	***ROE (with controls)***	***PEC***	***PEC (with controls)***
Treatment	2.001***	2.288***	0.515*	0.518*	0.506***	0.506***	0.452*	0.456*
	(0.295)	(0.329)	(0.223)	(0.223)	(0.104)	(0.104)	(0.202)	(0.203)
Age		-0.015		0.001		-0.015**		0.007
		(0.014)				(0.004)		(0.009)
Female		0.654*		0.010		-0.159		0.387
		(0.317)				(0.102)		(0.212)
Rural		-0.138		0.047		0.033		-0.012
		(0.389)				(0.111)		(0.228)
Student		-0.287		-0.206		-0.119		0.135
		(0.718)				(0.206)		(0.504)
Unemployed		-1.395		-0.154		-0.392*		-0.208
		(0.838)				(0.197)		(0.439)
Retired		1.472**		-0.002		0.032		0.261
		(0.565)				(0.176)		(0.301)
Constant	-1.919***	-1.987**	-2.768***	-2.838***	-2.846***	-2.002***	-2.725***	-3.419***
	(0.206)	(0.714)	(0.157)	(0.502)	(0.081)	(0.241)	(0.141)	(0.528)
Observations	301	299	1,191	1,191	5,942	5,942	1,468	1,468
AIC	290	280.24	621.5	632.9	-	-	-	-

*Notes: The dependent variable is a binary indicator equal to 1 if terrorism is mentioned among the two most important issues and 0 otherwise. Treatment equals 1 for respondents interviewed after the attacks and 0 for those interviewed before the attacks. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. France and neighboring-country models are estimated on the unweighted sample, while rest-of-Europe models use entropy-balancing weights. For the rest of Europe (ROE) sample and Previous Exposure Countries (PEC), the weighted Logit is estimated within a survey design framework, treating the entropy-balancing weights as calibration weights. All models in the columns labelled "with controls" include age, female, rural residence, and occupation controls. *, **, and *** denote statistical significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels, respectively.*

Table F8. Odds Ratios from Logit Models (±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variables	***France***	***France (with controls)***	***Neighbors***	***Neighbors (with controls)***	***ROE***	***ROE (with controls)***	***PEC***	***PEC (with controls)***
Treatment	7.448***	9.858***	1.672*	1.680*	1.660***	1.660***	1.572*	1.578*
95% CI	[4.21, 13.44]	[5.26, 19.27]	[1.07, 2.59]	[1.08, 2.60]	[1.35, 2.03]	[1.35, 2.03]	[1.05, 2.33]	[1.05, 2.35]

*Notes: The table reports exponentiated coefficients from the Logit models, expressed as odds ratios. The 95% confidence intervals are reported in brackets. Treatment equals 1 for respondents interviewed after the attacks and 0 for respondents interviewed before the attacks. Models for France and neighboring countries are estimated on the unweighted sample, while rest-of-Europe and PEC models use entropy-balancing weights within a survey design framework. *, **, and *** denote statistical significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels, respectively.*

Table F9. Average Marginal Effects from Logit Models (±1-Day Bandwidth)

Variables	***France***	***France (with controls)***	***Neighbors***	***Neighbors (with controls)***	***ROE***	***ROE (with controls)***	***PEC***	***PEC (with controls)***
Treatment	0.394***	0.409***	0.036*	0.036*	0.033***	0.033***	0.032*	0.032*
	(0.057)	(0.054)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.014)	(0.014)

*Notes: The table reports average marginal effects from the corresponding Logit models. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. The marginal effects represent the change in the predicted probability of reporting terrorism among the two most important issues associated with the treatment indicator. Models for France and neighboring countries are estimated on the unweighted sample, while rest-of-Europe and PEC models use entropy-balancing weights within a survey design framework. *, **, and *** denote statistical significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels, respectivel*